

Client On-Boarding

The following summary relates to content stored in the Client On-Boarding section of Advisor-e. This content is designed to help advisors secure advisory engagements with new and existing clients. This content is suitable for new and experienced advisors.

1. 1st Response Email

- **Benefits:** This template establishes a structured, "Agile Theory" project management approach right from the initial inquiry. It breaks the engagement into Feasibility, Planning, and Implementation stages.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It reduces the business owner's risk and upfront costs by using a metaphor of "assessing structural integrity" before committing to final budgets, ensuring they only pay for a targeted feasibility stage initially.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It helps the advisor qualify prospects and secure an upfront fee (e.g., \$5,000 + GST) for the initial discovery and feasibility work, rather than doing this work for free. It also sets clear expectations for the client's time commitment (e.g., 5 hours and 3 meetings).
- **Who it is suitable for:** Advisors or consultants responding to a prospect's initial tender, project inquiry, or request for time.

2. Advisory Pricing Model

- **Benefits:** This comprehensive spreadsheet template provides a modular pricing and scoping framework for a wide variety of advisory services, ranging from strategic planning and marketing reviews to detailed M&A due diligence.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It provides the client with extreme transparency, showing exactly what objectives are being tackled, the number of meetings, and the specific time and value allocated to each component of their business development.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It allows the firm to calculate profitable pricing by assigning specific hourly rates to different team members and tracking travel, prep, and advisory time. It also includes a robust scoping model to ensure complex jobs, like due diligence, are sequenced and costed thoroughly.
- **Who it is suitable for:** Accounting and advisory firms that need to standardize their pricing structure, delegate tasks to a team, and scope complex multi-stage consulting projects.

3. Advisory Proposal

- **Benefits:** This slide deck template visually and logically structures a service pitch following a discovery meeting.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It clearly links the owner's desired "Milestones" and goals with their specific "Legitimate Constraints" (what is holding them back), ensuring they feel heard and understood. It also breaks down the investment into manageable monthly payments.

- **How it helps the advisor:** It creates a professional, persuasive narrative that guides the prospect from their problems to the advisor's recommended solutions and required investment. It also includes a standardized "Variation to Scope of Works" to cleanly handle future out-of-scope requests.
- **Who it is suitable for:** Advisors presenting a formal plan of attack and fee structure to a prospect after an initial discovery session.

4. Get. TCM.Quiz Link Email

- **Benefits:** A brief, low-friction communication designed to generate immediate client engagement.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It respects their time by taking less than 3 minutes to complete on a smartphone and helps them immediately focus on what needs attention in their business over the next 90 days.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It acts as a quick lead-generation or diagnostic tool, allowing the advisor to collect preliminary data and follow up with highly targeted guidance.
- **Who it is suitable for:** Advisors looking to re-engage their existing client base or warm up prospects with a simple interactive assessment.

5. Get. 5 Layers Questionnaire

- **Benefits:** An extensive, color-coded diagnostic tool (Green, Yellow, Orange, Red, Grey) that covers the entire business lifecycle from launch to maturity and exit.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It prompts deep critical thinking, asking the owner to evaluate their financial models, marketing awareness, team functionality, risk management, and succession plans, helping them identify operational blind spots.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a structured agenda for a discovery meeting (focused on identifying problems, not immediate solutions). By the end of the questionnaire, the advisor has a clear understanding of the client's readiness, budget, and timeline to begin a business development program.
- **Who it is suitable for:** Advisors conducting deep-dive strategic planning sessions or formal discovery meetings to uncover wide-ranging business issues.

6. Get. Invitation Email

- **Benefits:** Provides three different tonal options (Enthusiastic, Conservative, and a "Mental Gym" metaphor) for inviting clients to a cloud-based business improvement portal.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It clearly explains the value of the new portal (24/7 access, centralized meeting notes, action plans, and problem-solving templates) and provides simple, step-by-step registration instructions.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It streamlines the onboarding process for new tech tools, frames the portal as a high-value service, and includes automated steps (like unlocking resources only after the client registers) to drive client compliance.
- **Who it is suitable for:** Firms rolling out a new client-facing software platform or business improvement portal and needing to drive user adoption.

7. New Client Details Form

- **Benefits:** A standardized administrative document to capture structural, contact, and financial information.

- **How it helps the business owner:** Ensures all of their primary and additional trading entities, shareholding splits, and preferred income types (salary, PAYE, drawings) are documented accurately for compliance and billing.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Centralizes critical onboarding data, preventing administrative errors and ensuring the firm has all necessary tax numbers, billing addresses, and digital profiles (website, Facebook) on file.
- **Who it is suitable for:** Administrative staff and advisors formally onboarding a new business client.

8. Schedule Based Pricing

- **Benefits:** Provides a framework and presentation to explain workload management, priority service fees, and necessary fee increases.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It gives them the option to pay a "Priority Schedule Fee" to jump the queue if they have urgent deadlines (like bank covenants or trust payments), treating it like "business class" priority baggage.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It allows the firm to smooth out their 12-month compliance workload by categorizing clients, monetizing rush jobs to cover staff overtime, and provides a scripted email template to justify fee increases using logical reasons (cost of living, compliance intensity).
- **Who it is suitable for:** Accounting firms facing seasonal bottlenecks, needing to implement priority pricing, or preparing to communicate a price hike to their client base.

Summary Table of Provided Sources

Source Name

1st Response Email

Advisory Pricing Model

Advisory Proposal

Get. TCM.Quiz link email

Get.5 Layers Questionnaire

Get.Invitation email

New Client Details Form

End of Year Content

The following summary relates to content stored in the EOY (End of Year) Notes & Docs section of Advisor-e. This content is designed to help advisors secure advisory engagements with new and existing clients. This content is suitable for new and experienced advisors.

E.O.Y Approach Resources (Video, Quiz, Scripts, and Emails)

- **Purpose:** This template provides outreach materials (emails, text messages, phone scripts, and video links) to connect with clients, qualify prospects, and prime them for their End of Year (EOY) meeting.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It prompts the owner to reflect on their business management strengths and weaknesses and primes them to prepare for potential economic "ups and downs".
- **How it helps the advisor:** It offers a "micro-step" between the initial approach and the first meeting, helping to qualify prospects and significantly improving client engagement rates (especially when sent via text message).
- **Indicators for use:** The client is either a new prospect or an existing client being invited to an EOY meeting, or the advisor wants to transition the client into the "Lite Fundamentals" selling process.

2. E.O.Y Client Review Sheet - Input

- **Purpose:** A comprehensive diagnostic checklist used to review a client's business across multiple dimensions, including Governance, Ownership, Structure, Management Reporting, Financials, Technology, Taxation, and HR.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It provides a holistic health check of their business, uncovering blind spots related to business value, risk management, succession planning, and technology usage.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It acts as a structured framework to assess the client's current status and deliberately identify "Opportunities for Further Assistance" (advisory services or cross-selling).
- **Indicators for use:** The client has a multi-faceted business, is asking questions about structural or tax efficiency, or the advisor wants to conduct a thorough pre-meeting audit to spot advisory opportunities.

3. EOY Presentation Decks (Frame, Agenda, V2, and Rural)

- **Purpose:** A series of visual slide decks designed to structure the EOY meeting. They smoothly transition the conversation from reviewing historical accounts to discussing

advisory concepts like the "Growth Curve," "Volatility," and creating a "Start, Stop, Keep" action plan. The "Rural" deck is specifically tailored for farming clients, while "V2" focuses on exploring revenue capacity.

- **How it helps the business owner:** It helps them visualize complex business concepts, such as where they sit on the 9-stage Growth Curve, and guides them in creating tangible action steps for the future. For farmers, it aligns their timeframe with strategic spending (e.g., new tractors vs. overseas holidays).
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a visual, step-by-step agenda that controls the meeting's pace, handles psychological framing (bridging the "Personal Zone" to the "Business Zone"), and standardizes the delivery of advisory concepts.
- **Indicators for use:** The client is scheduled for an annual accounts review. You would use the *Rural* deck for agribusiness clients, the *V2* deck for clients needing to focus on revenue probability, and the standard *Agenda* for clients experiencing cash or sales volatility.

4. EOY Scripts Only

- **Purpose:** A dedicated document containing the psychological framing structures, rehearsal reminders, and specific dialogue prompts for introducing concepts like the Growth Curve or Volatility Report.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It ensures the meeting is communicated in a way that resonates with their specific mindset (macro-vision vs. micro-vision) and keeps them engaged.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides exact wording to assert status, assume permission, and navigate difficult client temperaments (e.g., an "Angry Couple," a "Depressed Guy," or an "Extremely withdrawn" client).
- **Indicators for use:** The advisor is preparing for a meeting with a challenging or emotional client, or the advisor needs to rehearse how to seamlessly introduce complex advisory concepts without sounding unprepared.

5. General Agenda

- **Purpose:** A recurring meeting agenda template used to document session objectives, track specific agenda items, and record future action points.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It holds them accountable by tracking whether previous action plan tasks were completed and keeps the current meeting focused on specific, written goals (e.g., "failed to secure enough sales").
- **How it helps the advisor:** It standardizes meeting documentation and provides a reliable paper trail of client progress and task completion across multiple coaching or advisory sessions.
- **Indicators for use:** The client is engaged in an ongoing coaching or advisory relationship that requires regular, structured follow-up meetings.

6. Management Reporting Annual Plan (Advisory Board Plan)

- **Purpose:** A 12-month calendar template scheduling specific operational and strategic topics for an Advisory Board or management team (e.g., Strategic Planning in Feb, Budgets in April, Tech/Risk in Sept).
- **How it helps the business owner:** It instills a disciplined, year-round corporate governance structure, ensuring that all vital areas of the business are reviewed annually without being overwhelming.

- **How it helps the advisor:** It creates a clear roadmap for recurring advisory revenue, detailing exactly what board packs and reports (e.g., Sales Manager Report, KPI Reports) need to be prepared each month.
- **Indicators for use:** The client's business is mature enough to require an Advisory Board, or the client needs structured, monthly management reporting and governance.

7. EOY Quiz Questions

- **Purpose:** A brief questionnaire template designed to test the client's knowledge of fundamental business metrics, such as customer acquisition costs, variable vs. fixed costs, and shareholder loan accounts.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It forces them to reflect on their financial literacy and highlights specific blind spots in their understanding of their own business costs.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It quickly identifies gaps in the client's financial knowledge, allowing the advisor to tailor the upcoming meeting to those specific educational needs.
- **Indicators for use:** The client struggles with pricing, cash flow, or understanding their fixed vs. variable costs, or the advisor wants a quick assessment of a new prospect's financial acumen.

Summary Table of Templates

Template Name	Primary Purpose	Best Suited For
E.O.Y Approach Resources	Outreach tools (videos, texts, emails) to prime clients for meetings.	Pre-meeting engagement and qualifying prospects.
E.O.Y Client Review Sheet	A comprehensive checklist to audit a client's business health and needs.	Uncovering cross-selling and advisory opportunities pre-meeting.
EOY Frame (Slide Deck)	Visual slides to psychologically frame the transition to advisory services.	Starting the EOY meeting effectively.
EOY Meeting Agenda (Slide Deck)	Core visual presentation to review accounts, the Growth Curve, and Volatility.	Standard business clients needing strategic review and action plans.

EOY Meeting V2 (Slide Deck)	Alternative visual presentation focusing on the Growth Curve and Revenue Capacity.	Clients whose primary focus needs to be on probability of revenue.
EOY Rural Meeting (Slide Deck)	Tailored visual presentation for the farming sector (Strategic Spending, Farmer Growth).	Agribusiness and farming clients.
EOY Scripts Only	Dialogue prompts and role-play guides for managing client psychology.	Rehearsing for difficult clients or practicing new advisory concepts.
General Agenda	A recurring document to track meeting objectives and task accountability.	Ongoing coaching or advisory engagements.
Management Reporting Annual Plan	A 12-month schedule mapping out topics for management or board meetings.	Mature businesses requiring structured governance/advisory boards.
EOY Quiz Questions	A short questionnaire evaluating a client's knowledge of basic business costs.	Assessing financial literacy and identifying areas for client education.

Growth Fundamentals Framework

The following summary relates to content stored in the Growth Framework section of Advisor-e. This content is designed to help advisors secure advisory engagements with new and existing clients. This content is suitable for new and experienced advisors.

The Growth Fundamentals Framework provides a comprehensive roadmap for a company's evolution, beginning at the Design phase and progressing through nine distinct Growth Stages toward an eventual Exit or Decline. To successfully navigate this journey, the model identifies seven strategic tactics and nine core aspects, such as Process Improvement and Customer Focus, that must be managed simultaneously. A significant portion of the material focuses on the psychological barriers and psyche errors—including confirmation bias and complacency—that can hinder a leader's progress during critical transitions. Specifically, the "Devil's Toilet" serves as a metaphor for the treacherous period between achieving a stable lifestyle and scaling for leverage, where fatigue often stalls momentum. By balancing financial levers with an awareness of complexity layers, business owners can better recognize their current position and prepare for the next tactical shift. Through this integrated approach, the framework aims to help entrepreneurs achieve sustainable expansion while avoiding common cognitive traps and operational plateaus.

The provided sources comprise four distinct presentation slide decks that collectively form the **Growth Fundamentals Framework**. Here is a review of these templates, outlining their core purpose, benefits, client indicators, and a summary table.

Purpose of the Templates

The templates are designed as a **comprehensive framework to guide the thinking, observation, reflections, and actions of those striving for business excellence**. They map the lifecycle of a business onto a 'Sigmoid-type/Sine Wave-type Curve' to illustrate the regenerative aspects of growth. The framework breaks business growth down into **9 Growth Stages** (from Design to Exit/Decline), **7 Growth Focus Tactics**, **5 Layers of Complexity (and associated Psyche Errors)**, and **9 Growth Aspects**.

How it Helps the Business Owner

- **Establishes Context:** It helps owners recognize exactly where they currently sit on the growth curve based on where they have come from and where they are headed.
- **Creates Self-Relevance & Motivation:** By contextualizing their journey, it creates "Self Relevance," which is critical for learning and developing the motivation to act.
- **Proactive Problem Solving:** The framework highlights the types of issues owners can expect to encounter *before* they actually have to cope with them, ensuring they are better prepared to handle dangerous stages like the "Devil's Toilet" (profit plateaus).
- **Identifies Roadblocks:** It clearly defines "What Got You Here" versus "What Holds You Back" for each stage, helping owners see missing skill sets or psychological traps holding back their growth.

How it Helps the Advisor

- **Structured Facilitation:** It provides advisors with a step-by-step "Reveal Format" to draw the curve freehand in "3x3 chunks," allowing for measured, interactive discussions with clients.
- **Improved Client Engagement:** By utilizing storytelling and "personas" (e.g., "Bob the Chocolate maker"), the advisor can discuss concepts in the third person. This creates dissociation—avoiding judgment, reducing jargon, and helping the advisor overcome the stereotype of being a purely analytical or "boring" accountant.

- **Scalable Service Delivery:** The templates offer two distinct engagement models: a **"Full" version** (involving 3-5 meetings, upwards of 10 hours, aimed at complex businesses) and a **"Lite" version** (a focused 1-meeting engagement for smaller clients with lower fee tolerance).

Indicators That the Template is Appropriate for a Client

- **Experiencing Stagnation or Fatigue:** If a client is experiencing a "profit plateau" or extreme fatigue after putting in significant effort, they may be stuck in the "Devil's Toilet" and need the framework to navigate toward the "Leverage" stage.
- **Exhibiting Psychological Roadblocks ("Psyche Errors"):** If an owner is showing signs of *Confirmation Bias* (ignoring reality to maintain focus), *Complacency* (inability to focus on the external environment after reaching perceived security), or *Role Identification* (acting how they think a "Boss" should act rather than being authentic), the framework is highly applicable.
- **Facing a Transition or "Split Point":** Clients who are unsure whether to continue scaling or prepare for succession/exit can benefit from the framework's detailed breakdown of the "Maturity," "Leapfrog," and "Exit/Decline" stages.

Table of Templates Listed as Sources

Template Name	Core Focus & Contents
Growth Curve	The core visual map of the framework. Contains the master tables mapping the 9 Growth Stages to the 7 Tactics, 9 Aspects, and the 5 Psyche Errors. Introduces metaphors like the "Devil's Toilet" and the 8 Profit Levers.
Growth Curve Story	An illustrative, narrative-driven deck. Provides character-based visual metaphors for each of the 9 stages, detailing the core growth focus, 3 fundamental requirements per stage, and "What holds you back."
Reveal the Curve	A facilitation guide instructing the advisor on how to draw the curve "freehand" for the client. Includes the exact questions to ask to test understanding and script examples for using third-person personas.

**Growth Fundamentals
Framework Philosophy**

The foundational theory behind the framework. Explains the "Why" of the framework, breaks down the "Lite" vs. "Full" service offerings, and includes story fables (e.g., The Bear and the Salmon, Barney the Badger) to teach Psyche Errors.

Have you ever like looked at a struggling business, maybe a a local coffee shop that just suddenly closed down or even a massive tech startup making headlines for laying off half its staff and wondered if their problems were, I don't know, entirely predictable? Oh, yeah. I mean, we definitely have this tendency to think of business failures as these sudden chaotic events, right? Like a bad month, a sudden shift in the market, or just a stroke of really terrible luck. Exactly. But what if there was an actual road map that plotted out exactly when a business would hit a wall. Like what if you could point to a specific spot on a curve and say, "Right there, that is the exact psychological trap the owner is falling into today."

Wow. I mean, if you could do that, it completely changes the paradigm of how we view success and failure, doesn't it? It really does because it removes the mystery. You know, we're essentially talking about moving from reactive crisis management where you're just putting out daily fires to predictable systemic growth. So, you basically stop ing what the problem is because the map already told you it was coming. Yes, exactly that. Okay, let's unpack this because honestly that is the mission of our deep dive today. We are exploring something called the growth fundamentals framework.

It's a fascinating concept. It really is. And to be clear for you listening, whether you're an entrepreneur trying to, you know, just survive the week or an adviser trying to guide a client out of a ditch, this isn't just dry academic theory. It's a highly practical philosophical blueprint, right? It proves that businesses rarely die from just bad luck. They die from highly predictable structural and uh psychological blind spots. Yeah. And before we get into the actual mechanics of this framework, we need to understand why we even need a structured map in the first place. Right.

Definitely. And it comes down to human nature. By default, human nature pushes us toward the new and the fresh. We love the shiny new thing. Exactly. Once an entrepreneur thinks they know something, they just want to sprint to the next exciting milestone. But a framework acts as this forced mechanism for thinking, observation, and reflection. So it forces you to slow down, right? It forces the business to ask, have we actually mastered the fundamentals of where we are right now? Or are we just building a taller tower on a really shaky foundation?

Oh, that's a great way to put it because expansion without fundamentals is well, it's just a countdown to a collapse. Precisely. I want to make this tangible for the listener. The source material actually suggests using a persona to understand this framework. So, let's uh let's introduce a character to guide us through this. I love that idea. Let's call him Bob the Chocolate Maker. Bob the Chocolate Maker. Perfect. Right. So, Bob makes these incredible artisal chocolates in his kitchen and he wants to build an empire. The framework lays out the map of Bob's journey through nine distinct stages of growth.

Nine stages. Correct. Right. And it shows where Bob came from, where he is now, and where he's headed. So, walk us through that. How does Bob's journey start? Well, Bob's journey starts with the design stage. So, he's, you know, developing his chocolate recipes, figuring out his branding, and getting ready to quit his day job. That exciting early phase. Exactly. Then comes the launch stage. He officially opens his doors or uh his online shop. From there, if he sells enough chocolate, he hits the break even stage where his revenue is finally covering his costs,

which has to be a huge relief for Bob. But the framework points out that break even leads directly into the first major geographical hazard on the map and I love the name for this. They call it the devil's toilet. It is a wonderfully visceral term, isn't it? It really is. What exactly is the devil's toilet? So, the devil's toilet is that treacherous swirling profit plateau situated right between break even and the next stage, which is lifestyle. Okay, so what's happening to Bob in the toilet?

Well, in the devil's toilet, Bob is making enough to keep the business alive, but he is just exhausted. He's constantly paddling just to keep his head above water, working like 80 hours a week. Oh. Oh man. Yeah. And he's probably taking home less than minimum wage when you actually do the math. That sounds miserable. So, he's trapped in this swirling vortex of just barely surviving. Let's say Bob paddles hard enough and escapes the devil's toilet. Good for Bob, right? He reaches the lifestyle stage. The business finally makes enough profit to comfortably fund his life. He can take a vacation, maybe save some money.

And from lifestyle, he moves to leverage where the business sustains itself without Bob having to be hands-on tempering chocolate. every single day, right? He's built a real system. Ah, but right after leverage, the map presents another massive hazard. Okay. What's this one? The split point. The split point. Yeah. It's the ultimate fork in the road and it forces a decision based entirely on competence. At this stage, the business has grown significantly and Bob has to recognize his own missing skill sets.

Meaning, he has to realize what he's not good at. Exactly. If he acquires those skills or, you know, hires people who have of them, he can take the higher path on the curve toward reach, which means expanding to multiple locations. Right. Right. And then

Leaprog, which involves acquiring competitors. And finally, maturity, where Bob's chocolate company commands major market share with massive barriers to entry. Okay. I'm looking at the split point concept, and I'll be honest, it feels a bit harsh.

How so? Well, are we really saying that if Bob lacks one specific skill, his only option is to fail? I mean, is there no middle ground where he just stays a happy medium-sized company? Well, it's not necessarily an overnight failure, but the framework argues that businesses are dynamic. You know, they're either growing or they're dying. Oh, I see. Yeah. If Bob reaches the split point and fails to adapt or bring in the right management skills, he takes the lower path. And that path leads to exit or decline.

Oh. Now, exit could mean he successfully sells the business while it still has value, which is a win. But if he refuses to sell and he can't adapt the business, business enters a slow, painful decline because it missed the mark for sustained growth. The market just moves on without him. It sounds like a video game where you absolutely cannot skip to the final boss. Like you have to unlock the basic levels first. And if you don't have the right inventory or skills for the next level, you just lose.

That's a great analogy. But business never really feels like a straight line, does it? No, it definitely isn't. And the framework totally acknowledges that. It is a twisting winding curve. Yeah. At each individual stage from design all the way to maturity, the business must pause. Okay, Bob has to look around and ask, "Do we truly understand this level? Do we execute consistently? Have we mastered it?" So, you can't just sprint ahead. Right? If he tries to skip a level, say trying to franchise his chocolate shop before he's even mastered break even, the market will ruthlessly send him right back to the start.

Wow. Okay. So, that gives us the physical map of the journey. But knowing the map isn't enough to get to the destination. Right. Not at all. You need to know how to drive the vehicle forward. And maybe even more importantly, you need to understand the psychological blind spots that will cause you to drive the car straight off a cliff. Exactly. And this brings us to the next core component. The framework combines the seven growth focused tactics which act as the engine of the business with the five layers of complexity.

And the layers of complexity represent the driver's mind. Right. Yes. The tactics are the actionable behaviors and they change depending on where you are on the map. Give me an example. So in the early stages like design and launch, Bob's required tactic is simply enthusiasm and creativity. He just has to put his head down, hustle, and get the chocolate into people's hands. Just sheer willpower, right? But when he hits the lifestyle stage, pure hustle doesn't work anymore. The tactic shifts entirely to clarity and strategy. He has to learn that sometimes less is more.

And as he moves into leverage and reach, the tactics change again. The framework lists delegation, replication, or quantification. I want to stop on that last word for a second. Delegation and replication make sense. Like Bob hires managers and opens identical stores, but what does quantification actually look like in a day-to-day business setting? Are we just talking about aggressively measuring KPIs? It's uh it's deeper than just looking at a spreadsheet. Quantification means taking the intuitive magic that Bob has in his head and turning it into measurable objective data that literally anyone can follow.

Okay. So getting it out of his brain. Exactly. Instead of Bob saying, "Oh, the chocolate feels ready." Quantification means establishing that the chocolate must be tempered at exactly 88° for precisely 12 minutes to achieve a 99% consistency rate. Oh, wow. Yeah. You quantify the art so the business can scale without relying on Bob's personal intuition. And later, if he hits the leapfrog stage, the tactic shifts again to alliance and acquisition. But the tactics alone aren't enough to save him. Because here's where it gets really interesting. The framework introduces these five layers of complexity and it maps them directly to what it calls psyche errors.

Yes, these are basically the psychological traps laying weight for the owner. Right? This is perhaps the most profound part of the entire philosophy. Honestly, identifying the dominant psyche error is just as critical as identifying your next tactical focus. Okay, let's go through them. Let's look at the first layer of complexity foundation. The principle here is keeping an open heart and an open mind to understand how things actually work. But the dominant psyche error is confirmation bias.

So like Bob is so in love with his initial recipe for spicy dark chocolate that he ignores the market feedback telling him everyone actually just wants to buy his milk chocolate. Right. He only listens to the three customers who agree with him. Exactly. Then he moves to the second layer orientation. This is about understanding your purpose and meaning. Knowing your why and the trap there, the trap lying in weight there is complacency. Yeah. Bob hits the break even or lifestyle stage. He gets able the bills are paid and he just stops pushing to improve.

Makes sense. The third layer is intelligence. The source material defines this as contextual awareness. Learning to notice what you don't know. And the trap here is optimism bias. So let's say Bob has had some solid success. He's reached the leverage stage and he starts to think he's invincible, right? He underestimates the risks of opening a massive new factory and completely overestimates his own brilliance as a CEO, which leads right into the chaos of the fourth layer. expansion. The core principle here is managing the chaos of interdependency. The framework explicitly states there is a very fine line between expansion and explosion

and the psychological trap. The trap at this layer is the mere exposure effect which the framework defines as overexposure. Hold on, I want to clarify this one because in traditional psychology, the mere exposure effect usually means people prefer things simply because they are familiar with them. Are we using a slightly different definition here? We are in the context of this business framework. It refers to the danger of stretching the brand, the team, and the owner way too thin just for the sake of getting bigger.

Oh, I see. Yeah. It's the assumption that just because you can expose your business to new markets or massive new product lines, you should like Bob starts making chocolate scented candles and chocolate themed clothing, right? He overexposes the business to unnecessary risk and completely loses his core focus. That makes total sense. You spread yourself so thin that the original product suffers and that brings us to the final and maybe the most difficult layer of complexity, succession. This aligns with the stage of maturity and eventual exit. The fundamental principle required here is the separation of value and worth.

As the framework beautifully puts it, Bob has to learn to get out of his own way. And the psyche error trying to sabotage Bob at this final stage is overidentification. I find this so fascinating. The biggest threat to a growing business isn't necessarily a massive new competitor or a supply chain failure. It's the owner's own ego. It really is. Bob literally cannot separate his personal self-worth from the value of the chocolate company. If we connect this to the bigger picture, it explains why so many successful founders spectacularly fail at passing the torch or selling their company.

They just can't let go. Right? You can have the perfect tactic, a flawless legal strategy for an acquisition, but if the driver's mind is blinded by overidentification, m If Bob subconsciously believes that selling the company means he ceases to matter as a human being, yeah, the tactic fails, he will sabotage the deal. The psychology overrides the strategy every single time. Wow. So, we have the map, which are the nine stages. We have the engine and the driver, which are the seven tactics and the five psychological layers.

Correct. But even if Bob's psychology is perfectly in check, and he knows his next milestone, the daily grind can still tear a business apart. How do you keep the lights on while chasing that growth? And that brings us to the balancing act. The nine grief aspects. Okay, what are those? These are the fundamental tasks that must be completed effectively at every single stage of business growth regardless of whether you are in launch or maturity, right? And the sources list them out. Process improvement, customer focus, sales, authenticity, inventory and equipment, team focus, innovation, governance, and harmony balance.

That's a lot to keep track of. It is. And I don't want to just Read a list. Imagine you, the listener, are trying to juggle nine glass balls while climbing a really steep, winding staircase. That juggling analogy is perfect. Let's look at Bob. If Bob focuses purely on the sales ball and the innovation ball to get to the next step, so he's selling tons of crazy new chocolate flavors, but he completely drops the inventory and equipment ball. What happens? Disaster. Exactly. His tempering machines break down from overuse. He runs out of cocoa beans, and he literally can't fulfill those sales. The supply chain shatters.

Or what if he focuses heavily on process improvement and team focus building this hyperefficient corporate machine, but he drops the authenticity ball? Oh, that's a bad one. Yeah. Suddenly, his artisal chocolate tastes like mass-produced plastic, and his original loyal customers just abandon him. Right. The framework's philosophy is that these nine aspects ensure the business remains structurally sound and isn't overly consumed by the pursuit of raw growth. It keeps things stable. Yes. And two of those glass balls are particularly fragile and incredibly vital to the whole system. Governance and harmony balance.

Governance sounds so formal. I know people hear governance and they think of boring corporate paperwork. But governance is your long-term vision, your strategic planning, your risk management and harmy balance. That refers to removing distractions, ensuring physical and mental well-being, and taking time for financial recovery. Wait, that's Bob's actual health. Yes. If Bob doesn't sleep, Or if he drains his personal bank account to fund the business, he loses his balance. Exactly. They are the structural glue. If you don't maintain awareness of all nine aspects at every stage, the business eventually collapses under the weight of its own unbalanced expansion.

Okay. So, what does this all mean for the people actually trying to help business owners? Wow. We've built this massive intricate framework. We understand the physical curve, the psychological traps, the juggling act. How does an adviser, a consultant or even an internal management team use this tool in the real world to generate value. It comes down to something the framework calls self-relevance. Think about a typical consulting dynamic. When an adviser walks into a room and points out a business owner's flaws, saying your supply chain is a mess and you have an ego problem, walls go up immediately.

Oh, yeah. Defensiveness kicks in immediately, right? But the framework offers a brilliant facilitation step. You reveal the growth curve via a persona. Which is exactly why we've been talking about Bob the chocolate maker this whole time. Precisely. Instead of an adviser saying you are failing because you are trapped in complacency, the adviser puts the map on the table and says let's look at this curve through the eyes of Bob. Ah, I see.

Bob is right here in the devil's toilet. And Bob is struggling with optimism bias. He thinks he can borrow his way out of a cash flow problem.

It creates dissociation. You keep things in the third person. So, client doesn't feel judged before they even understand the concept. It gives the adviser permission to use humor, to exaggerate the scenarios, and to cut through all that dense, intimidating business jargon. Suddenly, you aren't the boring analytical accountant delivering a lecture. You are a storyteller. And storytelling makes clients want to engage. They can look at Bob's problems on the map and safely say, you know, my business is actually doing exactly what Bob is doing. I think I'm in the devil's toilet, too.

It completely removes the shame from the equation. It is a profound shift in how advice is received. And the payoff isn't just for that one one-on-one relationship, is it? The source material highlights massive benefits for an entire advisory firm, plus all the external advisers they collaborate with. Oh, absolutely. I'm thinking about the lawyers, the bankers, the external marketing agencies, the centers of influence. Usually, it's chaos. The lawyer says, "Protect all your assets." The marketer says, "Spend heavily on ads." And the accountant says, "Cut all your costs. the owner is just being pulled in three different directions.

But when everyone uses this framework, everyone is literally on the same page. That shared visual map is transformative. I bet when an entire team of advisers speaks the same language. It determines a standardized learning path for new staff at the firm. It makes communicating the value of an intervention vastly easier. It aligns everyone. Yes, you enable a highly effective leveraged approach to team advisory. The accountant the marketing consultant and the lawyer are all pointing to the exact same stage on the exact same curve agreeing on the exact tactic required for that specific moment.

It basically acts as a universal translator. You're no longer arguing about opinions or gut feelings. You're just pointing at the map and looking at the mechanics of the machine. What's fascinating here is that by removing the emotion from the advice by using the persona, the stages, and the shared visual structure, you completely transform what is usually a stressful antagonistic intervention into a collaborative strategic partnership. The business owner finally feels understood. Exactly. And the advisory team actually has a predictable leveraged path to offer them.

It really is a master key to bring it all together for you listening. The growth fundamentals framework isn't just a fancy chart to hang in a boardroom. It is a comprehensive philosophy. It combines the nine geographic stages of growth, the tactical engine to drive you forward, the deep psychological layers of the driver's mind, and the nine juggling aspects to keep the whole thing from falling apart on the journey. It takes the

terrifying unpredictable chaos of running a business and turns it into a manageable predictable science.

And the true power of this philosophy is in anticipation. It allows you to highlight the structural and psychological issues that you can expect to encounter long before you actually have to cope with them in real time. So the next time you look at a problem in a business, whether it's a massive corporation in the news, your favorite local coffee shop, or your own daily grind. Don't just ask what is going wrong right now. Ask yourself where are they on the curve and what underlying psyche error is blinding them to the solution.

That's spot on. And uh this raises an important question and something I'd love to leave you to ponder. Okay, let's hear it. We talk about the final stage of an owner's journey succession and how it requires the profound psychological separation of their personal worth from the business's value. Right. Getting out of your own way. Exactly. But what happens if a founder builds their entire brand brand and identity around themselves from day one. If their face is the logo and their personality is the product, can a business ever truly exit or successfully outlive its creator if the founders's own ego was the foundation it was built upon?

Wow, that is definitely something to chew on. The X-ray machine for a business might not show a clean break, but this framework proves that the muddy waters of growth are actually entirely mappable as long as you have the courage to look at the psychology behind the numbers. Thank you so much, for joining us on this deep dive. Stay insanely curious. Keep looking at the map and we will catch you next time.

General Tools

The following summary relates to content stored in the General section of Advisor-e. This content is designed to help advisors secure advisory engagements with new and existing clients. This content is suitable for new and experienced advisors. The content is primarily of an EDUCATION nature and therefore, is better suited to younger advisors or those looking to build confidence and skills in the advisory market.

1. 6 Hats Thinking

- **Purpose:** To introduce a framework for collaborative "parallel thinking" over traditional "argument thinking," helping teams avoid confirmation bias and cross-purpose discussions.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It **directs the minds of the team** using a shared structure and language, ensuring everyone focuses on the same topic and views issues from multiple perspectives (creative, critical, emotional, etc.), which enhances problem-solving and innovation.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It **increases the effectiveness of business planning sessions** 10-fold by getting all participants focused and using the same terminology.
- **Indicators for use:** The client's team frequently experiences conflict, confusion, ego-clashes, or "trips over each other" during meetings.

2. 90 Day Accounting Best Practice Plan

- **Purpose:** A 90-day training program covering four key sessions (Coding, Transactions, Quality Control, and Close Off) to teach best practices for using financial software like Xero.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It **prevents costly mistakes, "surprise" tax bills**, and ensures the business's chart of accounts is aligned with what the owner actually wants to measure.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It creates a paid, structured engagement (\$1,500 - \$1,800) and **prevents the advisor from having to untangle "birds-nest nightmares"** caused by untrained staff.
- **Indicators for use:** The client's financial administrator is out of their depth, the accounts require constant clean-up, or the client needs actionable KPI reports rather than just tax data.

3. Dashboard Discussions

- **Purpose:** A framework for evaluating financial ratios (e.g., Sales to Gross Profit, Wages to Sales) by breaking down costs into Variable (Do the Job), Activity (Get the Job), and Fixed (Get Organised) categories.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It helps them identify **the root causes of their financial data** (Cause - Event - Effect) and determine which tactical options will have the greatest influence on their business.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It sets the advisor's role to **"Challenge What You Believe To Be True,"** positioning them as a strategic partner who guides the client to look beyond just the numbers.
- **Indicators for use:** The client relies on assumptions instead of facts, struggles to interpret financial metrics, or needs help understanding how operational decisions impact profitability.

4. One Page Supposition (Accme Business Case)

- **Purpose:** A condensed business case template designed to evaluate the viability of a new idea by assessing the "Big Idea", target customers, revenue models, and the "Acid Test" (key obstacles and risks).
- **How it helps the business owner:** It forces them to identify potential competitive advantages, infrastructure requirements, and a **"Ripcord" strategy to collapse the business quickly** if it fails.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a rapid, structured way to assess a client's new venture without needing a 50-page business plan.

- **Indicators for use:** The client wants to launch a new product, pivot their service, or start a completely new business enterprise.

5. The 8 Profit Levers

- **Purpose:** To break down the components of profitability into 8 controllable levers: Foot-traffic, Prospects, Customers, Customer Spend, Customer Frequency, Sales Margin, Activity Costs, and Fixed Costs.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It visually demonstrates how **small, incremental improvements** across multiple levers (e.g., converting 20% of prospects instead of 8%) can lead to massive profit increases.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It transitions abstract financial goals into a concrete **Action Plan** where the advisor can assign specific tasks and deadlines to improve specific business functions.
- **Indicators for use:** The client wants to increase profits but doesn't know where to focus, or they are suffering from a "Profit Plateau".

6. Working Capital Cycle

- **Purpose:** To explain the flow of "Money in Movement" (Working Capital) versus "The cost of being in business" (Fixed Capital), highlighting how time delays affect cashflow.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It shows how **delayed collection cycles (e.g., 60 days vs 30 days) drastically reduce stock turn and available cash**, and demonstrates the danger of discounting prices.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It allows the advisor to model scenarios showing exactly how much working capital is needed to support growth, warning clients away from dangerous "over-trading" (funding growth primarily via debt).
- **Indicators for use:** The client is growing rapidly but running out of cash, considering discounting to win work, or using long-term debt to fund short-term stock cycles.

7. 4 Part Business Plan

- **Purpose:** A comprehensive planning tool combining Market Assumptions, Business Owner Expectations, an 8 Lever Action Plan, and a Revenue Model.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It aligns the **business's growth stages with the owner's personal goals** (e.g., desired income, weekly hours, weeks of annual leave) and clearly tracks business development over multiple years.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It secures long-term engagement by breaking growth into manageable stages (Stage 1, 2, 3) and mapping out the specific tasks required.
- **Indicators for use:** The client feels overworked (seeking "Ikigai" or purpose), wants to significantly scale up, or lacks a long-term strategic direction.

8. 3 Pillars of Financial Management

- **Purpose:** An educational template to provide practical steps for a business owner to learn financial management.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It breaks the process into actionable steps, starting with the 'math' of their own (business variable) assumptions via a suitable revenue model, then a systems review before suggesting they learn ratio analysis.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It secures long-term engagement by showing a progressive pathway to financial literacy - supported all the way by their trusted advisor.

- **Indicators for use:** The client fails to use financial management reports or seeks a cash forecast to support a funding application without knowledge of feasibility or ongoing performance reviews.

9. Debtor Protocols & Business Drag Model

- **Purpose:** Provides a step-by-step system, phone scripts, and communication templates (like the 'Lolly Letter') to recover outstanding debts, alongside a spreadsheet to model the financial "drag" of unpaid invoices.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It overcomes the **psychological barriers (like role-identification and fear of confrontation)** that stop owners from demanding payment, providing them with structured, polite, but firm methods to get their cash back.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It allows the advisor to implement immediate, tangible cash-flow improvements for the client, proving the value of the advisory relationship.
- **Indicators for use:** The client relies heavily on a few large customers who pay late, the person doing admin avoids calling debtors, or the client feels they have "no right" to demand payment.

10. Rubbish in - Rubbish Out

- **Purpose:** To establish clean financial data management by correctly organizing the Chart of Accounts into Variable, Activity, and Fixed costs (using a "Filing Cabinet" analogy).
- **How it helps the business owner:** It ensures they are gathering accurate data so they can measure the effects of major decisions (e.g., expanding premises or hiring) and **know early enough if a decision was wrong**.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It cleans up the client's books, allowing the advisor to generate accurate KPIs and measure what actually matters to the business's success.
- **Indicators for use:** The client cannot measure the impact of recent business changes, or their accounts are "jumbled up" and unhelpful for decision-making.

11. What's Applicable (Technology)

- **Purpose:** A review to identify where software and technology can be applied across business areas (Inbound, Outbound, Sales, Workflow, Inventory, etc.) to improve either efficiency or effectiveness.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It helps them identify repetitive, everyday tasks that can be **automated without reducing their effectiveness** with customers.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a structured way to audit a client's operational software and recommend tools (like CRM, workflow management, or OCR receipt feeds).
- **Indicators for use:** The client's administration is heavily manual, they struggle to track job costing, or their sales engagement is unorganized.

12. The Customer Journey

- **Purpose:** To map out the "Revenue Story"—how customers find, trust, and buy from the business—tracking the journey from Total Available Market down to Lifetime Customer Value.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It helps identify exactly **where the marketing or sales journey is "breaking down"** and prompts them to address the specific frustrations or frictions stopping target profiles from purchasing.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It broadens the advisory scope into sales and marketing, allowing the advisor to help construct outbound messaging and product reviews.

- **Indicators for use:** The client has high exposure but few prospects, or lots of initial sales but no loyal customers or referrals.

13. Demings Volatility

- **Purpose:** Explains that calculating simple averages is flawed for predicting performance; introduces Standard Deviation to plot natural business volatility.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It establishes a **"likely range" of performance**, helping them avoid making knee-jerk decisions when sales naturally dip, or becoming complacent when sales naturally spike.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a more sophisticated tool for forecasting and performance review, separating normal variation from actual business decline.
- **Indicators for use:** The client has a highly seasonal business, or frequently panics over month-to-month sales fluctuations.

14. Quick Fire Diagnosis

- **Purpose:** A rapid, 30-minute triage tool to determine if a business is in "Distress" or "Growth" mode, and to pinpoint the biggest problem areas across Getting Organised, Getting the Job, or Doing the Job.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It makes the **problem-solving logic "visible"**, moving them out of denial or confusion and empowering them with a clear path forward (whether that is salvage, liquidation, or growth).
- **How it helps the advisor:** It acts as a diagnostic roadmap, telling the advisor exactly which templates (e.g., Quick Position, Revenue Model, Lite Fundamentals) to use based on the client's current crisis or goal.
- **Indicators for use:** The client states "I'm unhappy about our business performance" or "I'm worried we might go under," but doesn't know the specific root cause.

15. The HOPE Recession Model

- **Purpose:** To map the standard economic cycle and explain the sequence of an economic slowdown: **Housing, Orders, Profits, Employment**.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It forces them to consider macroeconomic threats and develop a **Strategic Withdrawal Plan** (e.g., identifying assets to sell or staff redundancies) before emotional distress sets in.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It positions the advisor as a critical sounding board for risk management and contingency planning.
- **Indicators for use:** The broader economy is facing inflation or rising interest rates, or the client operates in a highly cyclical industry with no defensive strategy.

16. KPI's

- **Purpose:** A selection menu of Financial and Non-Financial Key Performance Indicators (e.g., WIP Days, Customer Satisfaction, Return on Assets).
- **How it helps the business owner:** Allows them to intentionally choose **what they want to "Pay Attention To"** and ensure their software is tracking it accurately.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It helps build standardized management reporting dashboards tailored to the client's goals.
- **Indicators for use:** The client is not tracking their performance, or they are tracking vanity metrics instead of actionable data.

17. Lite Feasibility

- **Purpose:** A tool for assessing the payback, risk, and break-even requirements of a specific asset purchase or funding request.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Helps calculate the required utilization rate of new equipment and identify a "**Ripcord**" strategy (how to sell the asset if the venture fails).
- **How it helps the advisor:** Provides a quick framework to validate or challenge a client's capital expenditure plans before they commit financially.
- **Indicators for use:** The client wants to buy new machinery, expand operations, or take out a business loan.

18. People vs. Process

- **Purpose:** A diagnostic tool to determine if operational failures are due to the People (Do they Know, Do, and Care?) or the Process (Six Sigma, Lean, Constraint Theory).
- **How it helps the business owner:** It clarifies exactly **where the bottleneck is**, preventing them from unfairly blaming staff for a broken system, or trying to fix a system when staff lack basic skills or motivation.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides an objective framework to analyze operational efficiency and customer promise alignment.
- **Indicators for use:** The client complains about staff performance, quality control issues, or frequent production bottlenecks.

19. Price Rise

- **Purpose:** An educational template for business owners to provide (two) methods for communicating a price rise to their customers.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It allows them to develop scripts based on their own personality and customer relationship dynamics.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It introduces the methods and scripts are provided to 'get the ball rolling' but are most certainly intended to be revised to suit each owner.
- **Indicators for use:** The client fears putting their prices up and lacks a method of communicating their position to customers.

20. Business Structure Options

- **Purpose:** Reviews the primary legal structures (Sole Trader, Partnership, Company, Trust) and explains the concept of the "Corporate Veil" and separate legal entities.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Ensures they understand **how to protect what they build**, how liability works, and how their structure impacts their ability to sell the business in the future.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Allows the advisor to have a proactive conversation about asset protection, succession, and risk without giving formal legal advice.
- **Indicators for use:** The client is starting a new business, operating in a highly litigious industry, taking on a partner, or amassing significant working assets.

Summary Table of Templates

Template Name	Core Purpose
6 Hats Thinking	Framework for parallel, collaborative thinking to avoid confirmation bias.
90 Day BP Acct	90-day accounting software training & best practice plan.
Dashboard Discussions	Framework for analyzing financial ratios and identifying their operational root causes.
One Page Supposition	Rapid business case assessment for new ventures or pivots.
8 Profit Levers	Breaks profitability into 8 controllable areas to create targeted action plans.
Working Capital Cycle	Visualizes the cashflow impact of delayed collections and inventory cycles.
4 Part Business Plan	Aligns the owner's personal income/lifestyle goals with multi-year business growth stages.
3 Pillars of Financial Management	Educates owners on the pathway to business financial literacy
Debtor Protocols	Scripts, models, and processes to overcome psychological barriers to debt collection.
Rubbish in - Rubbish out	Organizes the Chart of Accounts to ensure data accurately measures business decisions.

What's Applicable	Audits business operations to identify where software can improve efficiency and effectiveness.
Customer Journey	Maps the sales funnel to identify where marketing and conversions are breaking down.
Demings Volatility	Uses Standard Deviation to map a "likely range" for sales, proving averages are misleading.
Quick Fire Diagnosis	30-minute triage tool to determine if a business is in distress or growth and pinpoint the root problem.
The HOPE Recession Model	Maps the macroeconomic cycle to help clients build a "Strategic Withdrawal Plan".
KPI's	A selection menu for setting financial and non-financial metrics to track.
Lite Feasibility	Assesses the risk, break-even, and "rip cord" strategy for major asset purchases.
People vs. Process	Diagnoses if operational failures are caused by staff (Know, Do, Care) or broken systems.
Price Rise	Provides communication options to deal with price increases.
Business Structure Options	Explains the pros/cons of Sole Trader, Company, Trust, and Partnership structures for asset protection.

Imagine walking into a room, right, and across the table is a business owner who I mean, they just haven't slept properly in maybe three days.

Oh, yeah. You can see it in their eyes.

Exactly. They are bleeding cash. Their accounting software is a complete Well, it's a mess and they are looking directly at you to save them.

It's a lot of pressure.

The pressure is immense. And if you're listening to this deep dive right now, chances are you know that exact feeling of absolute terror.

Oh, absolutely.

Because you are a professional, right? You're looking to step into the world of business advisory. You have the experience. You have the drive. But sitting down with a struggling business and figuring out where to start, it can feel um completely paralyzing.

Yeah, it really can. But you know what? If I told you that your job on day one isn't to fix a single thing.

Wait, really? Not a single thing?

Not one. I mean, it completely shifts the dynamic. The anxiety that most new advisers feel, it usually comes from a well a misunderstanding of what the job actually requires in those early days. Right?

When we look at the overarching philosophy of delivering these advisory services, there's a very specific progression. It basically breaks down into three main types of client engagements. So you have education, facilitation, and advice.

And most people think they need to jump straight to advice.

Exactly. They think they have to instantly diagnose these deeply rooted complex problems and, you know, prescribe the cure on the spot.

Which is exactly why we We are diving into this uh really comprehensive stack of business advisory templates today because the core focus of this toolkit is heavily anchored in that very first phase education. Yeah.

And if you're a new adviser, I mean that should be a massive relief.

It takes the weight of the world off your shoulders honestly. Yeah.

Leaving with education means you are simply teaching the client the frameworks.

Yeah.

You're providing them with the vocabulary and the lenses to actually look at their own business objectively, often for the very first time.

You don't have to be the savior who untangles their their entire operational nightmare on a Tuesday morning.

Right. Right.

You just have to teach them how to read the map. Okay. Let's unpack this because before we can teach a client how to, you know, build a grand strategy or pull profit levers, we have to start with the absolute bedrock, the foundation.

Yeah. We have to educate them on their own data because you simply cannot build a 10-year vision on broken numbers.

No, you really can't. The foundational principle here is universally true, right? It's rubbish in, rubbish out.

Yep.

If the financial data entering the system is flawed, every single decision made downstream is going to be flawed. So, the methodology for data management in these templates is built around this relentless mantra. Get it in, get it clean, and make it count.

Make it count. I love that. And the practical tool for that is the 90-day best practice accounting plan.

Exactly.

And as an adviser, it's important to remember you aren't stepping in to do their daily bookkeeping. You are offering a structured plan to educate their administrative team, right? You're guiding them.

Yeah. And anyone in this field knows exactly why this is necessary because business owners adopt software like zero. They plug in their bank feeds and they think the software will just like magically do the work for them.

Oh, it's a huge trap.

They get completely out of their depth without even realizing it.

Yeah. They create what we call administrative debt.

Yeah.

The 90-day plan approaches this not as a checklist, but as a journey of transforming raw data into um basically defensive armor for the business.

Oh, I like that. Defensive armor.

Yeah. And it starts right at the source with coding and reporting. So, you sit down with their team for a session and teach them the mechanics of properly recording income, expenses, assets, and liabilities.

Getting the basics right.

Exactly. You show them how to flag tax deductibility issues the moment a receipt is entered rather than waiting for an accountant to find it, you know, a year later, which shifts the entire perspective. The accounts stop being this mandatory tax report for the government and become a real-time dashboard for the owner.

Yes, precisely.

From there, the education moves into the transaction platform. And let's be honest, invoicing looks incredibly simple to an outsider, right? You do a job, you send a bill.

Exactly. But any professional who has dealt with partial deposits, canceled orders, or uh bundling different services with different tax implications, they know this is where the bird's nest nightmares truly begin.

Oh, it is the most common point of failure by far.

The transaction process is where money is supposed to change hands and if the protocol is sloppy, everything else breaks.

It's like a blocked artery.

Yeah.

The heart is pumping furiously, meaning the business is working hard, delivering services, building products, but the oxygen, the cash isn't reaching the brain because the transactional pathways are just clogged with bad data and confusing invoices.

That is exactly the dynamic. Which is why the subsequent educational step is teaching them monthly quality control, catching the errors early, right?

You train their team to proactively hunt down those blockages. They learn to spot deposit refunds, overpayments, and you know, orphaned invoices before the month even closes. And finally, you teach them the 90-day close off. This is how you lock down the preceding quarter, make the necessary adjustments, and run an interim stock take. It essentially creates an airtight seal around their financial history.

So, we've guided them through cleaning up the rubbish. The data is now accurate.

Clean data.

Yes, clean data. So the next step for you as the adviser is to educate the client on where the business actually stands today. We have to diagnose the patient. Are they actively bleeding out or are they just coasting and wishing for more?

This brings us to a really crucial triage moment. When you sit across from an owner, you have to listen very carefully to how they frame their reality, right?

Because there is a massive operational difference between a client who says, "I'm worried we might go under." And a client who says, "I wish we were doing better." uh totally different mindsets entirely.

And those two statements require completely different educational paths.

Well, let's tackle the scary one first. If they say they're worried about going under, that is imminent risk. We don't talk about 10-year goals then, right? We teach them the quick position ratio.

Exactly. And the math behind the quick position is straightforward. It's cash plus debtors minus period expenses.

Simple enough on paper, right? But in a room with a panicked client, reciting a formula doesn't help. at all.

You have to ground that math in their immediate reality.

Make it real for them.

Yeah. So, imagine you freeze the business today. No more new sales. You sweep the cash register. You call in all the IUs from your reliable debtors and you pay this month's rent and payroll.

Okay.

How many days until the lights physically shut off?

Man, that is a stark, brutal reality check. It forces them to see exactly how many training cycles they can survive if their funding lines are maxed out.

It's sobering.

But let's look at the other scenario, the lights aren't shutting off. The business is surviving, but they want to grow. Here, the education shifts to the one-page supposition.

Right? So, this is a foundational business model framework. It basically covers the core mechanics, revenue, sales, production, retention, and the required infrastructure and nuts and bolts.

Yeah. And within this framework is a diagnostic tool called the asset test. You walk the client through identifying what we call the big wall.

And this isn't just like small everyday problems, right?

No, no, this isn't a list of minor annoyances. It is the single massive obstacle they absolutely must overcome to make the venture viable. And tied directly to that is evaluating risk versus return.

Like what's at stake exactly what is actually at stake for them personally if they hit that wall and fail.

And right below that in the framework is the RIP cord which asks the owner to clearly define how they will identify early failure and what the exact steps are to collapse the business and get out quickly.

Yes, the exit strategy. Now I have to push back on the psychology of this for a moment. You have an entrepreneur who is finally getting their data clean. They're looking at their infrastructure. They are motivated. Asking them to plan their exit strategy and business collapse right at this exact moment. Doesn't that create massive psychological friction?

Oh, it definitely does.

It feels like you are asking them to bet against themselves.

It creates friction, yes, but it is the ultimate act of protection. You have to establish the ripcord moment right now in the calm rational environment of the planning phase because later on it's chaos.

Exactly.

If you wait until the business is actually failing, their logic will completely evaporate. Emotions, wounded pride, and sheer desperation will cloud every single judgment.

Wow.

By defining the exact metrics of failure today, you prevent them from, you know, draining their children's college fund into a doomed venture just because they couldn't bear the emotional weight of letting it go.

That reframes it completely. It removes the emotion from the hardest decision they might ever have to make.

That's the goal.

So assuming the triage shows the business is viable, the rip cord stays tucked away, your next job as the adviser is to open the hood and show them the engine. How does this machine actually generate cash?

And this is where we introduce the working capital cycle.

The key educational hurdle here is getting the client to understand the fundamental difference between fixed capital and working capital.

Right? So fixed capital capital or structural requirements. That's just the price of admission. It's the rent for the building, the espresso machine on the counter, the basic wages. It's the money required just to exist.

Exactly. But working capital is money in movement. It is the money that actually makes money. The visual we use to teach this traces a very deliberate cycle.

Okay, walk me through it.

You start with cash in the bank. You use that cash to buy stock. You hold that stock until you make a sale. That sale often becomes a debtor, someone who owes you money, right? And finally, when they pay you, it turns back into cash and the cycle repeats.

Let's walk through a concrete scenario from the source material to see how this actually plays out on the ground. Imagine a local bar. They buy a premium chocolate bar to sell at the counter. Okay, it costs them 50 cents to buy and they sell it for \$2. If the customer hands over a \$2 coin, fantastic. The cycle completes instantly.

Perfect scenario.

But what happens if they sell that chocolate to a corporate client? hosting an event and there is a 14-day delay in getting paid. That tiny, seemingly harmless 14-day gap in the cycle dramatically alters their cycle factor.

It changes everything.

Yeah, they spent the 50s, but the \$2 is trapped in limbo. If rent is due on day 10, that quote unquote profitable chocolate bar just pushed them closer to insolvency.

It vividly demonstrates how money and movement dictates survival.

And once an owner truly grasps how that cycle functions, You can introduce them to the aprofit livers.

Ah, this is the good stuff, right? Most business owners operate in a state of baseline panic. When they want to improve the business, their only strategy is usually just we need to make more money, which isn't a strategy at all.

No, make more money isn't an actionable strategy. It's a wish. The core equation of business is total revenue minus total expenses equals profit. But those two massive buckets are actually controlled by eight distinct mechanical levers and the framework maps specific aims directly to these levers. Like if the client's aim is to gain more attention in the market, the lever they pull is number of foot traffic.

Yep.

If the aim is to secure custom, they focus on the number of customers lever. If they want to buy materials for less, they pull the sales margin lever.

What's fascinating here is how this immediately grounds the owner. Let's say we have a coffee shop owner who wants to increase revenue.

Okay,

instead of blindly spending thousands on Facebook ads to get new people through the door. You educate them on lever number five, which is average customer frequency.

Oh, getting the regulars back.

Exactly. You teach them to build a strategy solely around getting their existing morning regulars to come back one extra time a week for an afternoon tea.

That's brilliant, right? You haven't increased foot traffic. You haven't changed the margin. But by pulling just that one specific lever, the cascading effects on the bottom line are massive.

But, and this is a big butt, all the brilliant strategies and profit levers in the world mean absolutely nothing if the cash doesn't actually land in the bank account.

That is the harsh truth.

Managing the money is fundamentally more important than managing the work itself. History is entirely littered with brilliant, hardworking crafts people who built incredible products and went completely broke.

So many of them.

Which transitions us into what might be the most crucial and honestly often the most uncomfortable education phase debtor protocols.

Yeah, getting paid sounds like should be the easiest part of business, but it is deeply fraught. When you look at why businesses struggle to collect debt, it almost always comes down to three fatal mistakes.

Let's hear them.

First, they are too reliant on too few regular customers. This completely inverts the balance of power. The owner becomes terrified of upsetting a valuable client by demanding payment. So, they just quietly absorb the financial strain themselves.

Oh, that makes so much sense. And the second mistake from the sources is that their terms of trade are never backed up by a formal sitdown meeting at the very beginning of the relationship.

Yes. Skipping the hard conversation.

They are so eager to land a new contract that they skip the crucial step of looking a client in the eye and establishing exactly how and when money will change hands.

Exactly. And the third mistake is delegating the recovery to the wrong person. It is almost always handed off to an office administrator who sees it as an unpleasant adjunct to their real job.

Right. They didn't sign up for that.

No. They were hired to manage schedules, not to navigate the confrontational, emotionally charged reality of debt recovery. So, they send a passive aggressive email once a month and just sort of hope for the best.

Here's where it gets really interesting, because fixing this isn't just about accounting. This is an education in behavioral psychology. And the toolkit provides actual word-for-word scripts for the adviser to hand to their clients to dismantle these exact problems.

It's so practical.

Take the lolly letter for instance.

Oh, it's a brilliant tactical tool. This is for clients who are 30 days overdue. You send a physical reminder letter, but you attach a sweet a lolly to the paper, a piece of candy, right? It serves as a pattern interrupt. It softens the aggressive nature of late notice. While the text clearly and unapologetically states that the business cannot afford to pay its own staff if invoices aren't honored.

And if the candy doesn't work, you move to the 60-day follow-up script. And this isn't a script for aggressively demanding ing money. It is engineered to systematically lower the debtor's defensive shields.

Yes, it's very psychological.

It teaches the owner to start the phone call by identifying a global issue. You say, "The economy is really tightening up right now. Interest rates are hitting everyone hard." You establish a shared enemy.

You're in it together, right?

Then you bring in a local issue. My specific problem is that I have staff holiday pay coming up and equipment suppliers demanding cash upfront.

You're humanizing the debt. And then comes the structural hook, which is self-relevance. The script guides the owner to say, "And like you, I'm struggling to get what I'm owed. So, if you helped me out by paying just some of this invoice today, would you still be able to get through your own month?"

Wow.

It completely shifts the dynamic from a hostile demand to a mutual problem-solving exercise.

It's a masterful way to navigate the conversation. But to get a business owner to actually pick up the phone and read that script, you first have to educate them on the internal psychological barriers that are holding them back. You have to teach them about psyche errors.

These are the subconscious traps owners fall into. The most common is role identification.

Playing the boss.

Exactly. The owner creates a mental image of how a successful boss should act. They want to be the visionary, the creator. Chasing down a \$1,000 invoice feels beneath that crafted identity. So, they distance themselves from the gritty reality of their own cash flow.

Then you have optimism bias. This is the dangerous habit of actively deleting or ignoring negative information. They look at a mounting pile of unpaid invoices and convince themselves, "Oh, they're good for it. They'll pay next week." Just to protect their internal belief that the business is thriving.

It's a survival mechanism, but a bad one. And finally, you have complacency, which stems from a loss of cexis energy.

Cexis energy.

Yeah. Cexus is the physical and emotional life force we pour into our goals. After months of stress, they simply run out of that energy. They become exhausted and lose the sharp focus required to consistently chase down the money.

Now, I can hear the professional listener thinking about this, and I want to voice a natural concern. Sending a piece of candy attached to a late notice, calling up a client and asking for just some of it so you can make your own payroll, doesn't that risk making the business look incredibly weak?

Fair question.

Doesn't airing your own financial stress to a client shatter your professional authority?

It is a very common fear, but the framework counters that perspective entirely. There's a quote from the source says, "If you want to play with the big boys, you better have a big boy bank account."

Ah, right.

The education here is about establishing permission and promise from day one. You look the client in the eye during that initial sitdown meeting and say, "We promised to deliver this project on time. And if we fail, you have permission to hold us accountable. In return, we need your promise to pay on the 20th. And if you can't, I need your permission to follow up persistently. Are we agreed?"

That's powerful. Setting those rules doesn't make you look weak. Establishing boundaries is the ultimate display of professional doggance, clarity, and respect.

Okay, let's look at what we've accomplished. We have the data clean. We've diagnosed the patient and set the rip cord. We've shown them how to pull the profit levers, and we've implemented the DTOR protocol, so the cash is actually flowing.

It's a lot of ground work.

It is. At this point, the adviser can finally zoom out and educate the client on the big picture.

And this is the dashboard discussions phase. You introduce a 3x3 matrix. for reviewing performance data.

Okay, what does that look like?

Let's say you were looking at a sudden drop in cash reserves.

Yeah,

the matrix asks you to trace the cause, the event, and the effect. The event is the low cash. The cause might be a delayed manufacturing project. The effect is a potential missed payroll next week.

Breaking it down logically.

Exactly. You teach them to look at how they get organized, get the job, and do the job. You break down variable costs versus fixed costs in real time.

And all of that structural analysis feeds directly into the four-part business plan. So pillar one establishes the market assumptions. Pillar two defines the business owner expectations.

And that's not just growth, right? And this isn't just about company growth. It asks how much personal income they want, what their risk tolerance is, and exactly how many weeks of annual leave they demand. Pillar three is integrating that eight lever action plan we discussed earlier. And pillar four is modeling the best probable world.

But the element that truly elevates this final stage of Education is the integration of ekiguai. It's a Japanese concept that translates roughly to a reason for being.

It is such a powerful alignment tool. Eeky sits at the intersection of four vital elements. What you love, what you are good at, what you could be paid for, and what the world needs.

And exploring this with a client reveals exactly why they might be feeling miserable despite running a functional business.

Oh, totally.

If an owner has what they love, what they're good at, and what the world needs, but they haven't figured out how to get paid for it. They experience delight and fullness, but zero wealth, right?

Conversely, if they have what they can be paid for, what they are good at, and what the world needs, but they no longer love it. They end up financially comfortable, but burdened with a profound feeling of emptiness.

I really appreciate how this framework grounds all the operational mechanics we've been dissecting. It is a vital reminder for the adviser that you aren't just sitting in a room optimizing spreadsheets and supply chains. You are using financial data to help a human being engineer actual satisfaction and purpose in their daily life.

If we connect this to the bigger picture, this entire journey illustrates why starting with education is the ultimate strategy for a new adviser.

Yeah.

When you walk a client through their data, when you help them face their psyche errors, when you align their business with their ike guy, you naturally build an unshakable foundation of deep trust. And once you have established that trust, trust the door effortlessly opens for you to transition into those more complex stages of facilitation advice later on.

It is an incredibly robust toolkit for anyone stepping into this arena. You don't need all the answers on day one. You just need to guide the education. But as we wrap up this deep dive, I want to leave you with one final thought to maul over. We spent a lot of time today exploring psyche errors like optimism bias and role identification and how they completely blind business owners from seeing the truth about their own companies.

They're sneaky. perhaps.

But as a newly minted adviser, as you step into this brand new professional identity yourself, which of those exact same psyche errors might be blinding you right now as you look at your own potential in this industry?

Oh, that raises an important question. Are you playing the role of an adviser? Or are you actually ready to do the work?

So, what does this all mean? It means the blank page shouldn't intimidate you anymore. You have the frameworks. You have the tools. Thank you so much for joining us on this deep dive. Now, it's time to take that first step. Up.

Lite Fundamentals

The following summary relates to content stored in the Lite Fundamentals section of Advisor-e. This content is designed to help advisors secure REGULAR advisory engagements with new and existing clients. The content is a combination of EDUCATION and FACILITATION and therefore, is better suited to advisors who have previous experience in running client meetings without supervision. In a nutshell, the lite fundamentals postulates that every business needs to practice the fundamentals to be successful over time. The Lite Fundamentals are a collection of business concepts that make up the 80/20 level of education required to allow a Mum and Dad or privately owned business to be profitable over time.

The Lite Fundamentals Components framework outlines a holistic approach to business management by categorizing operations into three primary stages: preparation, client acquisition, and operational execution. To organize the business, leaders must align their strategic planning with essential data analysis to ensure goals are grounded in reality. The sales and marketing phase focuses on identifying the right audience and converting leads into active revenue. Finally, the model emphasizes optimizing human resources and refining internal processes to ensure work is completed efficiently and consistently. By connecting these six pillars into a unified system, organizations can track key performance metrics and maintain a continuous cycle of operational improvement.

1. Prospecting Templates ("Lite Funda Call & Email")

Purpose: These are exact phone scripts and email templates designed to invite existing clients or cold prospects to complete an online business quiz. **How it helps the business owner:** It provides a highly accessible, low-pressure entry point (a 3-minute quiz done on a smartphone) to assess their business's opportunities and threats confidentially. **How it helps the advisor:** It gives the advisor a conversational, non-threatening reason to reach out, generating leads by offering a "no harm, no foul" follow-up chat based on the quiz results. **Indicators of appropriateness:** The client is either an existing accounting client who might need growth support, or a cold prospect who presents professionally online and looks like they "strive to do better".

2. Sales Process Templates ("Get.Lite Sales Prompts" & "Lite Visuals")

Purpose: This is a step-by-step presentation slide deck and accompanying advisor script to guide a prospect through a "Lite Fundamentals Sales Meeting". The script utilizes the "S.P.I.D.E.R." framework (Show, Pin, Investigate, Determine, Ensure, Reveal). **How it helps the business owner:** It helps them identify exactly where their business currently sits on the "Growth Curve" and clearly illustrates the structural blockages holding them back. It provides them with a vision of potential revenue improvements without demanding an immediate commitment. **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a repeatable, psychologically structured sales track that builds the client's desire for the program. It also scripts exactly how to set boundaries, requiring three specific commitments from the client (time, focus, and a regular monthly fee arrangement) before working together. **Indicators of appropriateness:** The client has completed the initial business quiz, is open to discussing their results, and desires to improve their revenue or overcome business constraints.

3. Formal Engagement Template ("Lite Fundamentals Proposal")

Purpose: A formal, customizable service proposal document outlining the scope, deliverables, and pricing for the "Lite Fundamentals" program. **How it helps the business owner:** It provides total transparency on what the program entails (broken down into Getting Organised, Getting Work, and Doing Profitable Work) and outlines exactly what is required from them to get started. **How it helps the advisor:** It formalizes the commercial relationship, commits the client to an 8-meeting schedule, establishes fixed monthly fees, and protects the advisor's time by including a "Variation to Scope of Works" template for any out-of-scope requests. **Indicators of appropriateness:** The client has responded positively during the sales meeting, verbally agreed to the program's three conditions, and is ready to review the financial investment.

4. Business Planning Template ("Lite Strategy")

Purpose: A comprehensive business plan and strategic review document capturing the company's current state, future objectives, market assumptions, and profit metrics. **How it helps the business owner:** It directly connects their personal lifestyle desires (desired income, working hours, and weeks of annual leave) to specific, required business milestones. It also forces them to evaluate risks through an "Acid Test" to identify key obstacles and "ripcord" strategies if the business fails. **How it helps the advisor:** It serves as a central dashboard containing all the foundational data needed to consult effectively, such as identifying the client's current growth stage and documenting which of the "8 Profit Levers" to target for growth. **Indicators of appropriateness:** The client lacks a formal strategic plan, struggles to extract their desired personal income from the business, or is facing changing market forces that require a review of Porter's 5 Forces.

5. Educational Framework Templates ("Lite Framework Philosophy" & "Lite Fundamentals Components")

Purpose: Explains the foundational theory of the Lite framework, breaking business growth into 9 distinct stages, 5 layers of complexity/psyche errors, and 6 core components. **How it helps the business owner:** It creates "self relevance" by contextualizing their struggles, showing them what

got them to their current stage, what is holding them back, and warning them of predictable hazards like the "Devil's Toilet" (profit plateaus). **How it helps the advisor:** It offers a simplified, focused methodology compared to the more complicated "Full" Growth Fundamentals framework. This limits the scope of engagement, making it easier to sell to budget-conscious clients and allowing the advisor to become active with the client in just 3 weeks. **Indicators of appropriateness:** The client's business is relatively straightforward, cannot afford the premium \$30k+ fee range of a comprehensive 100-template framework, but still desperately requires structured growth assistance.

6. Advisory Delivery Modules ("Lite1.Planning" through "Lite6.Process")

Purpose: A series of six workshop presentation decks designed to facilitate the actual ongoing advisory sessions covering Planning, Data, Marketing, Sales, People, and Process. **How it helps the business owner:** It breaks complex business theory into actionable, step-by-step sessions. For example, it teaches them to separate cash flow problems from profitability problems, how to map the 4 levels of consumer awareness, how to script for sales tension points, and how to implement feedback models for staff. **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a complete, ready-to-teach curriculum. The advisor does not have to invent meeting agendas; they simply follow the slides to deliver consistent, high-value coaching across the entire program. **Indicators of appropriateness:** The client has formally signed the Lite Fundamentals proposal, set up their monthly payments, and is actively attending their scheduled advisory meetings.

Summary Table of All Templates Listed as Sources

Source Document Name	Primary Template Function
Get.Lite Sales Prompts	Slide-by-slide script/prompts for conducting the prospect sales meeting.
Lite Framework Philosophy	Foundational slides explaining the psychology, growth stages, and methodology behind the program.
Lite Funda Call & Email	Outbound communication scripts (phone and email) to generate initial quiz leads.
Lite Fundamentals Components	Visual diagram mapping the 6 core areas of business improvement.
Lite Fundamentals Proposal	Formal service agreement, pricing breakdown, and scope-of-work variation template.

Lite Strategy	Comprehensive business plan template for mapping goals, finances, and market strategy.
Lite Visuals	Client-facing visual presentation deck used during the initial sales process.
Lite1.Planning::	Workshop slide deck template for delivering Session 1: Planning.
Lite2. Data	Workshop slide deck template for delivering Session 2: Data & Financials.
Lite3. Marketing	Workshop slide deck template for delivering Session 3: Marketing.
Lite4. Sales	Workshop slide deck template for delivering Session 4: Sales Process.
Lite5. People	Workshop slide deck template for delivering Session 5: People & Leadership.
Lite6. Process	Workshop slide deck template for delivering Session 6: Systems & Processes.

So, what if I told you that being, you know, incredibly good at your job might actually be the exact reason your business is failing? I mean, it sounds completely counterintuitive, right? Yeah, it really does because we're all raised on this idea that the best baker naturally opens the most successful bakery or uh the most brilliant coder is automatically going to build the next massive tech startup. Right? But today, we're looking at a stack of proprietary playbooks that prove why the greatest artisans on the planet actually routinely make the absolute worst business owners.

It is a really harsh reality to face, but well, it's a necessary one. We are diving into a fascinating set of strategy and sales training documents from advisor-.com. Yeah. Specifically, their light fundamentals and their uh spiders sales framework. Right. Exactly. And what these sources do is they strip away all those romanticized myths of entrepreneurship and just replace them with raw mechanics. So, welcome to today's deep dive. Our mission for you today is noting the DNA of business growth and really digging into the hidden psychology of sales.

Whether you are currently trying to scale an empire or just running a side hustle from your kitchen table or or you just want to understand how top tier professionals persuade people without sounding like you know sleazy late night infomercial pitchmen. This is your shortcut. Exactly. So to start we really have to look at the architecture of a business because before you can sell anything you have to actually understand the machine you're building. Right. And the advisor-.com sources, they break a business down into this brilliantly simple hexagon model, they call it the six core light fundamentals components.

And I really love the visual of a hexagon for this because it instantly implies interconnectedness. Yeah. It's not linear, right? It's not a straight line where step one just leads to step two. It's a closed loop. So the model separates the entire operation into three major phases. So first you have the inputs which is your planning. data, right? Exactly. That's where you're getting organized. You're setting expectations and you're identifying which metrics actually matter to your survival.

And then those inputs feed directly into the second phase, the system, which consists of process and people, the engine room. Yeah, the engine room. It's where you make those incremental improvements and really get the most out of the human capital you've employed. Okay. So, if your inputs and your system are healthy, they automatically generate the third phase, right? The outputs. Right? Marketing and sales, that is who you want to speak to and how you actually win their business. See, the genius of the hexagon to me anyway is showing what happens when just a single side collapses.

Oh, absolutely. Like, let's say your outputs are incredible. You have this viral marketing campaign and sales are just through the roof. But your system is broken, right? Your processes are a complete mess. So, you end up winning all these new clients only to immediately lose them because your fulfillment is a total disaster. The whole structure just loses its integrity. It is a living breathing ecosystem that will absolutely bite back if you ignore any single side. And like any living ecosystem, it goes through distinct evolutionary phases, doesn't it?

It does. The sources detail this nine-stage growth curve. It begins at design where you're just sort of formulating the concept, just sketching it out on a napkin. Exactly.

Then you move through launch. You hit break even and aim for lifestyle. And lifestyle is where the business finally pays you enough to live comfortably, right? Right. And from there it scales up through leverage, reach, leapfrog all the way to maturity and eventually exit or decline. But right between break even and lifestyle there is this this terrifying little drought on the curve. And the documents give it a fantastically bleak name.

The devil's toilet. I mean, what a name. The devil's toilet. It really paints quite the picture, doesn't it? It does. You've survived the launch. You're making enough to cover your costs. And you are staring right at that comfortable lifestyle. stage yet. This is exactly where the vast majority of businesses just get flushed away. But why? I mean, what is actually pulling them into the plumbing? If they are breaking even, shouldn't momentum just naturally carry them forward? Well, momentum in the wrong direction is exactly the problem. The sources explain that escaping the devil's toilet requires moving into the orientation layer of complexity,

which they define as growth through clarity and strategy. Yes. Yes. Because up to the break even point, you relied purely on enthusiasm, creativity, and just working yourself to the bone. You were the artisan. Exactly. You were the one kneading the dough at 4:00 a.m. or writing, you know, thousands of lines of code, head down, just doing the hard yards, right? But shifting your mindset from artisan to owner isn't just a psychological exercise. It requires a really fundamental shift in your daily behavior

because the source has emphasized that sometimes less is more. You have to stop working in the business and start working on it. Think about what that practically looks like for a struggling founder on a random Tuesday afternoon. It means having the actual discipline to step away from the workbench, which is incredibly hard to do. It is. But if you lack clarity around your actual business metrics or you lack the discipline to delegate that artisan work, you just exhaust yourself. You tread water until you literally drown.

There's actually a perfect realworld example of this transition in the strategy documents. It's a sample business business plan for a company they call ABC Industries LTD. Oh, right. With the four owners. Yeah. Andy, Bill, Shirley, and Bob. They mapped out this highly detailed 5-year plan to grow their revenue from around uh \$840,000 to over 3 million. But the interesting thing is that the financial target wasn't even the focal point of their strategy. Exactly. Their primary focus was time allocation

because they realized that \$3 million in revenue would completely destroy them if they were still doing all the artisan work. Right. They explicitly targeted their weekly hours over 5 years. They plan to reduce their overall hours from 45 down to 30. That's a huge drop. It is. And more importantly, they tracked a specific metric called technician duties,

like the actual hands-on labor. They mandated reducing that from 10% of their day down to just 5%. And they created a brand new calendar category, didn't they?

They did. They called it fishing. They engineered a plan to increase their literal fishing time from 0% to 10%. See, that is the ultimate proof of surviving the devil's toilet. They aren't just hoping for more free time. They are mathematically engineering the machine to run without their physical labor. They're reallocating their energy toward, you know, strategic client dealing, team coaching, and yeah, actual recreation. Exactly. But wait, I have to say, viewing a business and its revenue as just a math equation feels incredibly clinical to me.

How so? Well, the sources lay out this exact formula for growth. Number of foot traffic multiplied by number of prospects multiplied by number of customers multiplied by average customer spend multiply by average customer frequency equals total revenue. Right? The core math. But human beings aren't calculators. You know, if the market tanks or a client is just having a terrible day, no mathematical multiplier on a spreadsheet is going to save your sale. It just feels too neat for a messy world.

I get that. But the world is messy, which is precise. precisely why the formula is necessary. It isn't meant to predict human emotion. It's meant to isolate variables to prevent owner panic. Owner panic. Yeah. When a business isn't making enough money, the artisan's instinct is to panic and change everything all at once. Like slash prices, fire staff, launch new product, buy a billboard, just total chaos. Exactly. This formula forces you to look at the actual structural bottleneck instead.

I see. It's almost like an audio engineer sitting at a massive soundboard in a recording studio. Oh, I like that analogy. Yeah, like you can't just slide a giant magical make more money fader all the way up and expect a hit song. You have to tweak these specific five revenue dials. And you also have to manage the three expense dials the sources mentioned, right? Sales margin, activity costs, and fixed costs. Those are your eight profit levers. And let's actually take your soundboard analogy a step further.

Okay, if you push the average customer frequency fader up too fast, meaning you're aggressively getting current customers to buy more often. Yeah. But you haven't adjusted the activity cost fader to hire more support staff. You blow out the speakers. Oh wow. Yeah. Your team just burns out because they can't handle the fulfillment volume. Exactly. That makes a lot of sense. And it's incredibly empowering for you as the listener. If you are overwhelmed by a stalling business, you don't need to fix the entire machine today.

No, you just need to identify which of those eight dials is currently stuck. Right. Like if your foot traffic is high, people are visiting your website, but your aspects dial is low. You

do not have a product problem. You have a relevance problem. Your headline isn't capturing attention. So, you focus all your tactical energy right there. You find the single lever constraining the system and apply pressure. However, and this is a big however, you can mathematically map out your profit levers perfectly. But if your outputs fail,

meaning you sit down across from a human being and simply cannot get them to say yes. Exactly. If that happens, the math is entirely useless. Which brings us to the psychology of the pitch because the light sales fundamentals section of these documents takes a hard pivot into actual human biology and honestly this blew me away. It's a really vital pivot. The sources introduce a concept called congruence. Okay, let's break that down. So, in old school, you know, 1980s sales training, professionals were taught to artificially manufacture rapport.

Oh, yeah. Like you walk into a prospect's office, spot a golf club in the corner, and spend 10 minutes pretending to be deeply passionate about their golf swing. Exactly. Oh, you play a title list. My uncle had a title list. It's just thinly veiled manipulation. It is. And modern consumers are hyper aware of this. They can smell it a mile away. Well, the sources say they don't just smell it. Their biology physically reacts to it. Yes. Because we are hardwired for survival and our social order is built on dominance hierarchies, which we now just call status. When someone approaches you with fake small talk, their intent does not match their words. They lack congruence

and the buyer's brain literally triggers a chemical response to that lack of congruence. Yeah. It floods their system with norepinephrine and epinephrine. They go into a heightened state of physiological alert. Yeah. Their primal brain treats your fake, overly enthusiastic smile as a literal predator threat because you're acting unnaturally. It's crazy, but it's true. Establishing congruence is about aligned intent, somatics, pace, and tonality. It's an unspoken physical position that signals to the buyer's primal brain, hey, I am not a threat. We are looking at a problem together and we can relax.

And to achieve that relaxed state, the playbooks provide a specific meeting structure. They call it the SPD framework. SPR and we really need to break down exactly how this functions because it is an absolute masterclass in removing friction. Let's do it. So the S stands for show your get out of jail card early. This is the immediate antidote to that epinephrine spike we just discussed. The script they provide is just disarmingly simple. I love this script. You start the meeting by saying, "Just so we're clear, the objective today is simply to share a concept and gain your feedback. If you like what you see, we may decide to talk further. If not, no problem. No one has to make any final decisions today."

You are openly handing them the exit door. You're declaring, "I am not here to trap you." Exactly. Which leads to the pin the tail on the donkey. Now, what does a childhood party game have to do with closing a deal? It's about getting the client to clearly identify and

articulate their exact problem out loud rather than you guessing for them and risking that lack of congruence. Okay. So once they pin the tail on the specific problem, you move to the align, investigate the blockages, you look at what is actually stopping them from fixing it themselves.

And interestingly, the sources apply this same logic to their cold calling scripts. Oh, right. When their advisers call a cold prospect, they don't just launch into a monologue. They ask for permission to send a text with a link to a 3minut smartphone quiz. It takes all the pressure off. Take 3 minutes on your phone and we'll review the results together. Because by having them take a quiz, you aren't interrogating them. You're sitting on the same side of the table reviewing third party data.

Exactly. And once you've investigated, you hit the determine or dangle the prize. This is where you establish the contract, right? Yes. You ask the client what the ideal outcome actually looks like you are dangling the vision of a fixed problem which leads naturally to Essure conditions are agreed you get verbal confirmation like if we can achieve that prize are you in a position to move forward right because you don't pitch a single thing until they agree to the conditions and finally the R reveal the golden key only at the very end of the meeting do you actually present your product or service as the specific key to unlock that prize

it's incredibly elegant it really is but we do must knowledge reality here. Even with perfect congruence, a great get out of jail card and the entire SPID framework deployed flawlessly, you will face friction. Oh yeah, the buyer will push back and anticipating that friction is the core of one of the most vivid analogies in the entire stack. The sources compare sales tension to a rugby match. I love this one. It's so good. In a rugby game, you know for an absolute fact that at some point there is going to be a scrum there. will be a penalty. There will be a line out.

You don't know the exact minute it will happen, but the probability is essentially 100%. Right? So, what do professional athletes do? They don't act surprised. They rehearse the play. And sales is exactly the same. The sources call it scripting for known tension points. Because when a customer inevitably says, "I have to think it over," or, "I need to check with my partner." That is just a scrum. Why stumble over your words? Your heart rate shouldn't spike because you should rehearsed the play for that exact moment.

But to run that play effectively, you have to know who you're actually in the scrum with, right? Which brings us to the four processing styles from Honey and Mumford that the sources introduce because every buyer processes risk and tension differently. And if you treat them all the same, you're going to trigger their defense mechanisms. Let's dive into the biological why for each of these four styles. Okay, first you have the activist.

These are impulsive, rapidfire decision makers. Their primal drive is momentum. I like it. I want it now.

So, when dealing with an activist, bogging them down in complex details or lengthy historical data will actually frustrate them, right? You handle their tension by giving them immediate actionable steps to purchase. Show them the button to press. Make it easy. Second is the pragmatist. They are a motive, but their defense mechanism requires reassurance. They need tangible proof that they aren't making a mistake. So, if a pragmatist pushes back in the scrum, you hand them the receipts, case studies, statistics, and verifiable data calm their nervous system.

Then third is the reflector. And this one is crucial because aggressive sales people destroy deals here. Making decisions actually disturbs a reflector emotionally. Their brain requires time to process a risk. So if you attempt a hard close on a reflector like if you lock that jail door, their epinephrine will spike immediately. You have to design your sales process to allow them to withdraw. You present the information Give them the get out of jail again and literally let them think about it.

Give them space. And finally, the theorist. These buyers need to feel a sense of ownership over the process. They want to help build the solution. Because if you just hand them a finished product, they will find flaws in it simply because they weren't consulted. So with a theorist, you invite them to the whiteboard. You ask for their input on customizing the final details. The ultimate takeaway here isn't that you have to perfectly psychoanalyze every single client within three seconds, right?

It's that your sales process must be flexible enough to accommodate whichever style emerges in the scrum. You aren't fighting their nature. You are building a system that absorbs it. And to tie this entire sales psychology together. Whether you are communicating with an impulsive activist or a data- hungry pragmatist, you must remember the golden rule the playbooks leave us with. Holes, not drill bits. Holes, not drill bits. It is is the definitive distinction between a feature and a benefit.

It takes that old adage of selling the sizzle, not the stake, and makes it undeniably practical. Imagine you have engineered this incredible product, a tungsten tipped drill bit. It is forged from the strongest materials on Earth. NASA wishes they had your metallurgical technology. That is the feature, right? But if you stand in front of a customer and talk about tungsten and heat resistance, their eyes will completely glaze over because nobody actually wants to own a drill. it. No, what they want the ultimate benefit is just a perfectly clean hole in their wall exactly where they want it with zero wasted effort or frustration.

You are selling the lack of frustration. You're selling the time saved. You sell the hole, not the drill bit. Look at the connective tissue of the journey we have taken through these playbooks today. It's pretty amazing. We started by mapping out the living ecosystem of a business. Identifying how to dodge the devil's toilet by enduring the painful psychological shift from a hands-on artist to a strategic owner. We explored how to mathematically engineer your fishing time by tweaking the eight profit levers on your soundboard without blowing out the speakers.

From there, we dove into the biology of the pitch, establishing physical congruence to prevent a predator threat response and using the spider framework to systematically remove friction. And finally, we prepared for the inevitable rugby scrums of sales by accommodating the four processing styles and selling the hole, not the drill bit. It's a profoundly comprehensive framework for navigating what is ultimately a highly unpredictable ecosystem. It is. But before we finish, there is one final concept buried in the acid test section of these strategy documents that fundamentally shifts how you should view that ecosystem.

The acid test is a series of brutal stress test questions about your business plan. Right. Yes. And the very last question is simply titled the rip cord. The sources demand that you answer this. How will you identify early failure? How can you collapse the business and get out? quickly planning for the absolute worst case scenario. That is jarring after spending all this time talking about growth multipliers and 5-year plans. It is jarring, but it's the ultimate proof of an owner's mindset. We spend so much energy designing perfect sales scripts and charting our path to the lifestyle stage.

Yeah. But this raises a critical question for you listening right now. Have you designed your rip cord in your current project, your corporate career, or your side hustle? What is the specific objective metric that tells you it is time to pull the chute. We started today by acknowledging that a business is not a piece of flat pack furniture. It's a living beast that can and will bite back. Recognizing early failure isn't pessimism, it's survival. Knowing how to feed the beast is essential, but true mastery is knowing exactly when to pull the rip cord and safely escape the cage. Take these mechanics, identify your stuck levers, bring that get out of jail card into your next high stakes meeting, and always know where your rip cord is. Thank you. Thank you for joining us on this deep dive.

Strategic Tools

The following summary relates to content stored in the Strategic Tools section of Advisor-e. This content is designed to help advisors secure advisory engagements with new and existing clients. The content is focused on FACILITATION and therefore, is better suited to advisors who have previous experience in running client meetings without supervision and are confident to deliver complex business concepts.

This presentation outlines a structured framework for conducting strategic business planning sessions aimed at uncovering hidden opportunities and creating actionable growth plans. The process is divided into four core planning domains: establishing financial and personal business targets, evaluating strategic orientation, improving organisational efficiency, and refining sales and marketing strategies. To facilitate deep analysis, the sources provide various theoretical frameworks—such as Porter’s Five Forces and the Blue Ocean Strategy—to challenge existing beliefs and explore new market possibilities. Participants are encouraged to engage in collaborative thinking and use contrast modeling to bridge the gap between their current operations and future goals. Ultimately, these slides serve as a comprehensive guide for facilitators and business owners to prepare for, execute, and document a rigorous review of their company's health and trajectory.

1. 80/20 Farm Plan

- **Purpose:** Applies the Pareto Principle (80% of results come from 20% of activities) specifically to agricultural businesses. It breaks the farm down into four focus areas: Financial, Herd, People, and Land Management.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Allows the farmer to choose specific focus periods (30, 60, 90 days), set realistic tasks, and map specific daily practices (e.g., herd hydration, pasture management, machinery maintenance) directly to financial consequences and key points of measurement.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Provides a structured, industry-specific framework to consult on farm metrics and translate physical farming activities into financial discussions.
- **Indicators for Use:** The client operates an agricultural or farming business and needs help prioritizing daily operations to improve financial yield.

2. 9 Growth Aspect Questions & Graphic

- **Purpose:** A diagnostic tool that divides a business into nine holistic aspects: Process Improvement, Customer Focus, Sales, Authenticity, Inventory & Equipment, Team Focus, Innovation, Governance, and Harmony/Balance.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Prompts deep reflection via specific questions on all facets of their business—from checking their ideal client profile to assessing their own physical fitness and work-life balance.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Acts as a comprehensive "health check" to uncover hidden bottlenecks, allowing the advisor to pinpoint exactly where the client needs the most strategic intervention.

- **Indicators for Use:** A new client onboarding process, or when an existing client feels "stuck" but cannot articulate exactly which part of the business is failing.

3. ADV.0. Planning Outcomes

- **Purpose:** Sets the agenda, collaborative rules, and scope for a strategic planning session across four domains: Business Targets, Strategic Orientation, Organisational Review, and Sales & Marketing.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Prepares them mentally to explore issues with an "open heart and an open mind," clarifying exactly what deliverables they will walk away with.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Defines the advisor's role clearly (to "Challenge What You Believe To Be True!") and provides a roadmap to structure the planning session without getting derailed.
- **Indicators for Use:** The beginning of any major strategic planning cycle or workshop.

4. Advance.1. Bizz Targets & BO Expectations

- **Purpose:** Helps define and map out tangible business targets (revenue, profit, debt) and aligns them with Business Owner (BO) lifestyle expectations (income, weekly hours, annual leave) across current and future stages. It also explores the 8 Profit Levers to tacticalize growth.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Forces owners to quantify their end-game and lifestyle goals, map their current business development stage (from Design to Maturity/Exit), and clearly see how their personal time must shift from technician duties to strategic duties.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Translates a client's abstract desires into a numerical roadmap, providing a clear mathematical and tactical gap analysis to consult against.
- **Indicators for Use:** Business owners who are burnt out, partners who have misaligned goals, or businesses needing to translate goals into mathematical targets.

5. Advance.2 & 2B. Strategic Orientation (Part 1 & 2)

- **Purpose:** Explores high-level strategic frameworks to review the business model. It utilizes tools like Porter's 5 Forces, Joseph Pine's Progression of Economic Value, the Sigmoid Curve, Blue Ocean Strategy, and Deming's Volatility Theory.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Challenges market assumptions, helps anticipate competitor/supplier movements, identifies when a product might become obsolete, and helps shift offerings from commodities to premium experiences. It also helps owners recognize their own "Psyche Errors" like Optimism Bias or Complacency.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Elevates the conversation from operational tactics to high-level market strategy, providing robust frameworks to guide clients through complex market environments.
- **Indicators for Use:** Clients facing heavy competition, market disruption, stagnant product sales, or those needing to rethink their fundamental value proposition.

6. Advance.4. S.W.O.T PEST

- **Purpose:** A traditional internal/external analysis matrix (Strengths, Weaknesses, Opportunities, Threats) combined with P.E.S.T. (Political, Economic, Social, Technological) prompts.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Provides a straightforward way to assess their current market position, internal resource gaps, and external regulatory or economic impacts.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Quickly captures a snapshot of the client's situational awareness and environmental risks.

- **Indicators for Use:** Clients needing a foundational baseline assessment before making a major strategic decision.

7. Advance.5. Sales & Marketing Review

- **Purpose:** Reviews the entire customer acquisition and retention journey using frameworks like the A.I.D.C.R.A model, 10 Critical Marketing Messages, Digital Funnel Storyboarding, and Packaging/Pricing options.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Shifts their focus from loving their product to understanding customer friction. It helps build a structured digital funnel to onboard clients and create sticky, concise marketing messages.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Provides a step-by-step diagnostic tool to find "leaks" in the client's sales pipeline and build a cohesive, multi-channel marketing plan.
- **Indicators for Use:** Clients with great products but poor sales, high customer acquisition costs, or those transitioning to digital marketing.

8. Advance.6. Organisational Review & Org Chart

- **Purpose:** Focuses on internal efficiencies and team engagement by mapping communication channels, defining cultural core values, and building formal Organizational Charts with clear reporting lines and KPIs.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Clarifies "who is responsible for what," helps define a safe social contract (culture) for the team, and establishes a military-style chain of command to ensure consistent actions under pressure.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Exposes structural bottlenecks, toxic cultural habits, or overlapping leadership roles that are hindering business execution.
- **Indicators for Use:** Companies experiencing rapid team growth, high staff turnover, operational chaos, or owners struggling to delegate.

9. Business Dating

- **Purpose:** Uses the metaphor of relationships (One Night Stand, Dating, Engaged, Married) to evaluate Alliance vs. Acquisition strategies based on the matrix of Attraction vs. Security/Commitment.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Prevents owners from rushing into a "marriage" (acquisition/merger) without proper due diligence or alignment of cultures.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Provides a non-threatening, easily understood metaphor to facilitate complex conversations about the risks of M&A and joint ventures.
- **Indicators for Use:** Clients considering buying a competitor, merging, or forming a deep strategic partnership.

10. Force Field Analysis

- **Purpose:** A conflict resolution and brainstorming tool to identify the forces pushing a group toward a goal and the forces holding them back.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Visually separates the people from the problem ("play the ball, not the player"), reducing guilt/shame while building urgency by defining the "Worst Case" scenario.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Acts as an excellent "bloodletting" exercise to manage a group with potential for conflict, enabling the advisor to unblock stalled planning.
- **Indicators for Use:** Teams facing internal resistance to change, conflict between directors, or a failure to execute past plans due to hidden fears.

11. Lite Strategy

- **Purpose:** A highly condensed, agile business plan encompassing the growth curve, target customer, ethos, profit levers, and a three-part market assumption test (Situation, Business Model, Acid Test).
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Gets the core business strategy down on paper quickly without being overwhelmed by excessive theoretical models.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Allows for rapid deployment of a strategic plan for clients who lack the time, budget, or complexity for a massive strategic overhaul.
- **Indicators for Use:** Startups, small businesses, or agile clients needing a fast strategic roadmap.

12. Pivot

- **Purpose:** A rapid framework (Identify Resistance -> Choose Fronts -> Rehearse Message -> Trial Prototype -> Review) designed for agile business owners to test new directions.
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Encourages testing ideas and messaging on a strict budget and timeline before committing massive capital to a full strategic shift.
- **Helps the Advisor:** Provides a structured way to guide an entrepreneurial client out of a crisis or into a new market iteratively.
- **Indicators for Use:** Clients facing a sudden market shock, an obsolete product line, or needing to quickly test a new idea.

13. Porter's & Pine

- **Purpose:** Fuses Michael Porter's 5 Competitive Forces with Joseph Pine's Progression of Economic Value (Extracting Commodities -> Making Goods -> Delivering Services -> Staging Experiences).
- **Helps the Business Owner:** Shows them how to escape price wars (commoditization) by elevating their product into a premium, authentic customer experience (like Starbucks did with coffee beans).
- **Helps the Advisor:** Provides a powerful visual narrative to convince clients that they must invest in customer connection and experience, rather than just lowering prices to fight competitors.
- **Indicators for Use:** Clients whose margins are being squeezed by competitors, or businesses struggling to differentiate their standard services.

Summary Table of Listed Templates

Template Name	Primary Focus / Domain
80/20 Farm Plan	Agricultural tactical planning & prioritization.

9 Growth Aspects (Questions/Graphic)	Holistic business diagnostic & health check.
ADV.0. Planning Outcomes	Setting expectations and scope for strategic planning.
Advance.1. Bizz Targets	Mathematical business goals, profit levers, and growth stages.
Advance.2 / 2B Strategic Orientation	High-level market models, product lifecycles, and psychological biases.
Advance.4. S.W.O.T PEST	Internal and External macro-environmental analysis.
Advance.5. Sales & Marketing Review	Lead generation, digital funnels, branding, and conversion.
Advance.6. Organisational Review	Culture, habits, leadership, and operational hierarchy.
BO Expectations	Tracking owner's personal income, hours, and task allocation.
Business Dating	Evaluating M&A, joint ventures, and strategic alliances.
Force Field Analysis	Change management, conflict resolution, and unblocking resistance.

GE: Org Chart / Org Chart	Defining reporting lines, roles, outputs, and duties.
Lite Strategy	A rapid, condensed business plan and assumptions test.
Pivot	Agile testing, prototyping, and rapid strategic shifts.
Porter's & Pine	Competitive market forces and experiential value progression.

You know, usually when we talk about a um a medical diagnosis, there's this expectation of real precision, right? It's almost like engineering or something. Yeah. Like you break your arm, the X-ray shows that jagged white line, and the doctor just points at the screen and says, "Well, there it is." It's binary. I mean, it's broken or it's not broken. It's clean. And honestly, it's comforting. We really like things to be visible and, you know, easily categorized. Exactly. But then you step into the world of running a business or even just steering a major project and suddenly that X-ray machine is just entirely broken. We're looking at a diagnostic landscape that is totally murky.

Yeah, completely. I mean, if you know your marketing is terrible, you just hire a marketer, right? But the real danger, the stuff that actually keeps leaders up at night are the blind spots, the uh the unknown unknowns, the things you don't even know are failing. Exactly. The systems that are quietly breaking down or even the massive opportunities we don't realize exist just cuz we don't know where to look. And that is exactly what we are tackling today. So welcome to the deep dive. Today we are talking directly to you the learner. We've got this massive stack of business planning templates, strategy reviews and uh growth frameworks.

Yeah, these are systems with names like advisor e pivot and light strategy. Right. And our mission today is to help you navigate these frameworks to basically answer one critical question. What don't we know that if we did know could give us a massive advantage because it is the absolute definition of diagnostic muddy waters out there for most leaders. But these frameworks, they act as a like a structured flashlight to shine

into those dark corners. Okay, let's unpack this because before we start blindly applying tactics or you know launching ad campaigns, we need a map. We have a foundational document here called the ADV0 planning outcomes template, right?

And it's essentially designed to answer that exact question by forcing you to well plan to plan. Yeah. It acts as a diagnostic tool first and foremost. It's designed to help advisers and their clients zero in on the frameworks that are actually most relevant to them right now. So, it stops you from getting distracted. Exactly. It lays out four distinct planning domains. You've got business targets, strategic orientation, organizational review, and sales and marketing review. So, it's like, well, you wouldn't want a surgeon operating on your knee if you went in for a migraine, right?

Definitely not. Is this planning to plan stage basically a triage process to stop business owners from operating on the wrong part of their company. It is absolute triage. I mean, so many leaders rush into executing some flashy new digital marketing campaign operating on the knee. Exactly. Operating on the knee when their actual problem is a completely misaligned overall strategy, the migraine. Wow. Yeah, that makes sense. So, by diagnosing the correct domain first, you identify which quadrants is actually holding you back. You uncover those unknown unknowns and you stop yourself from pouring energy, time, and you know, capital into solving the completely wrong problem.

Right? So let's say we've done our triage and we realize we need to start at the absolute beginning like defining what a healthy outcome actually looks like. The first domain exactly the business targets plan and looking at the structure of this in the sources. It is definitely not just a spreadsheet where you type uh make \$10 million next year and hit enter. Oh far from it. Uhuh. A true business target plan has to be holistic. It links sequential revenue and profit goals to really highly personal expectations like what?

Well, it forces the owner or the leader to calculate their personal income needs, their debt ratio, their risk tolerance, okay, and very importantly, their expected work hours and annual leave. See, let me push back on that specific point. Isn't mixing personal desires, like, you know, wanting to take a 3-week vacation in July with strict corporate revenue targets a bit like mixing oil and water? I can see why you think that. Like, shouldn't a business target be purely objective? I've well if we connect this to the bigger picture a business target is completely meaningless if achieving it burns out the owner the business is an engine and if the engine destroys the driver what was the point of building it in the first place that is a great way to put it the targets must serve the owner's life expectations not the other way around. If your model requires you to work 80 hours a week to hit your revenue goals but your personal target is 40 you don't have a

scheduling problem. You have a fundamental flaw in your business model. That is a massive perspective shift right there. The business serves the creator.

Exactly. And a key part of making that math actually work without destroying the driver seems to be what this framework calls the eight profit levers. Yes, the levers are crucial. It lists tactical actions like um gaining attention, capturing interest, securing custom, and buying materials for less. But how do these levers actually interact to prevent that 80hour work week? So the magic of those eight levers isn't in pulling just one of them really hard. It's the compounding math behind them.

Compounding math. Yeah. People often think they need to like double their sales volume to double their profit, which is exhausting, right? That means working twice as hard. Exactly. But if you increase your prices by just 2% and decrease your material cost by 2% and then increase your customer retention by 2%. You don't just get a 6% boost. Nope. Those margins multiply against each other. The compounding effect can completely completely transform your bottom line with a fraction of the effort.

So, you're just tweaking the dials instead of slamming the gas pedal. Exactly. But what if the vehicle itself is driving down the wrong road? Like, if we've set our t our destination, we still have to figure out how to get there in a really crowded market, which requires a very challenging honest review of the actual business model itself. And that takes us into domain two, which is strategic orientation. And there are some heavy-hitting concepts here in the sources. For instance, If our current product is selling incredibly well, human nature says, you know, don't fix what isn't broken, right?

So, how do we know when it's time to pivot or invest in a new idea? That's exactly the problem the Sigmoid curve is designed to solve. When you pair it with market diffusion theory, it shows that every single product goes through a predictable life cycle. Okay? You have your innovators, your early adopters, and then it hits a tipping point, usually around like 15% market uptake. From there, it just es into the majority, but eventually it reaches saturation, right? Like the absolute peak of the wave.

Yes. And after saturation always comes decline. The totally counterintuitive advice of the sigmoid curve is that the best time to invest in new ideas is while you are still enjoying positive cash flow from the existing product. Wow. Not when sales are dropping. Not at all. If you wait until the decline phase when competitors have crowded the market and your margins are shrinking, you simply won't have the cash reserves to afford the necessary research and development. It's like surfing. You have to start paddling for the next wave while you're currently riding the peak of the first one.

That's a great analogy. You're essentially acting as your own venture capitalist, using the cash flow from today's peak to fund the R&D for tomorrow's wave. Precisely. And

while you're paddling for that new wave, you have to rethink how you actually value what you're selling. And Joseph Pine's progression of economic value is like the perfect tool for this. Oh, the coffee bean example they used to illustrate This is just fantastic. Walk us through it. So, extracting the raw commodity, just the beans, gets you maybe two to three cents a cup, right?

But if you move up the progression and make goods by grinding and packaging it, you can suddenly charge 50. Big jump. Yeah. Then move up again to deliver services by actually brewing it for someone at a corner store. Now it's \$1.50. But the absolute peak is staging an experience to reach authenticity. That's how a premium cafe charges \$5 for that exact same two cent bean. And what's really important to grasp there is how the business imperative fundamentally changes at each of those stages.

How so? Well, when you sell a commodity, your entire operational imperative is just supply, logistics, availability, getting it there cheaply. Exactly. But when you reach the experience or authenticity stage, your operational imperative is rendering a feeling. The customer is gladly spending both time and money for that feeling, meaning you are no longer longer competing on price at all. Which naturally leads into the blue ocean strategy from the sources. If everyone else is fighting in the red water zone, which is that, you know, bloody water where competitors just claw at each other over price and convenience, that's exhausting, right?

Blueation is about finding uncontested space. You look at customer frustrations and just change the paradigm entirely. Susle is the classic illustration of this that they use. The traditional circus industry was dying basically fighting in red water over for who had the best clowns or the biggest elephants just competing on the same old metrics, right? Cirtole looked at customer frustrations like how society was getting increasingly uncomfortable with animal captivity and they just removed the animals completely which drastically reduced their costs.

Yeah. No elephants to feed or transport and then they replaced that with a high-end theater experience allowing them to charge Broadway level ticket prices. They created a parallel industry that they completely own. Yes, they made the competition irrelevant. But here's where Gets really interesting though. When you make a massive strategic shift like that, like taking the animals out of the circus, you're going to face friction. Employees might push back. Legacy customers might revolt.

Oh, definitely. How do you prevent a leadership team from panicking and abandoning the new strategy when that happens? You have to understand Peter Sen's circles of causality. It's essentially systems thinking. Okay. What does that mean in practice? It applies the physics law of equal and opposite reaction directly to organizational behavior. When you push hard to change a business model, the system pushes back.

So, it's not just a vague warning to expect bad things. It's a mechanical reality of how systems operate.

Exactly. Sen's model is all about feedback loops and delays. If you implement a new operational software or drastically change your pricing model, there is a systemic delay between implementing that change and the culture or market actually adapting to it. So, things get worse before they get better. You will see a dip in performance or morale. Sen tells us that dip isn't a failure. It's the predictable systemic resistance to change. If you expect it, you can push through it instead of panicking and reverting to the old failing model.

All right. So, we've defined our targets and we've navigated the strategic ocean to design this brilliant uncontested business model. But a great strategy is completely invisible to the consumer until you communicate it. True. How do we actually build the bridge between this theoretical model and the customer's wallet. That transitions us perfectly into domain three, which is the advanced sales and marketing review. This is where theory meets the market. The fun part for some. Yeah. And the fundamental goal here is to attract attention, convert that to interest, and secure custom.

And to do that, it seems like you have to start with a brutal ego check. The product fit review poses this fantastic question. Am I hoping my customers will do something that they're not motivated to do? It's such a necessary ego check. I mean, creators fall in love with their products features. We all do it. Oh yeah. But if the customer isn't naturally motivated to care about those specific features, you're pushing a boulder uphill. You are literally creating psychological resistance. Right. And to eliminate that resistance, the sources point us to the AIDC advertisement framework. Let's break down the mechanics of this because it's a lot.

Sure. So attention grabbing them, interest, creating self-relevance so they actually care. Desire. Yeah. Fueling their wants and needs. Credibility, right? Credibility, achieving status or authority in their mind. Risk removal, making it safe and easy to take the first step. And finally, action, telling them exactly how to purchase. It is a highly logical sequential order to construct any message, whether it's a physical billboard or a digital landing page. But let me challenge the practicality of this today. Advertising right now feels completely instantaneous. Everything is like a 3second social media reel or a fleeting banner ad. Is a rigid sixstep logical framework like AIDC just too slow and clunky for a modern digital funnel? Do we really have time to walk a consumer through six psychological steps?

Well, the delivery mechanism is certainly faster today, but human psychology doesn't change as fast as technology does. That's a fair point. A 3second reel can absolutely grab attention and generate interest. But if that reel drives a user to a landing page that

lacks credibility and doesn't offer risk removal, like maybe the return policy is hidden. Exactly. Or the site just looks unsecure. If that happens, the transaction simply won't happen. The brain's threat response kicks in. The aid CRA steps don't all have to happen in the same 3 seconds, but they must all sequentially occur in the customer's mind before they hand over their money.

So, the tech evolves, but the human brain doesn't. And that connects directly to the sparring or friction review. Yes, the friction review is critical. Once you've walked them through that psychological journey, you need to get perfectly clear on what customers will happily pay for, what they couldn't care less about, and what literally stops them from buying. You have to remove the physical friction from the process. Precisely. You might have generated immense desire. But if your checkout process requires them to create a 12 field user profile just to buy a t-shirt, that's friction.

Yeah, I'd leave immediately. We all would. They will abandon the cart. Okay, so marketing brings the customers to the door. We've removed the friction, but who is doing the actual work of serving them. A brilliant marketing engine will collapse overnight if the internal team can't deliver. Which brings us to the fourth domain, the organizational review. Right? This is the who in the engine. The focus shifts entirely inward to improving efficiencies, defining divisional roles, and fostering team engagement.

And the depth of the organizational charts they use here is intense. It really is. It focuses heavily on cascading operational objectives, meaning taking those massive company goals and break breaking them down so every single layer of the team knows their specific metric. Yes, very specific metric. For example, it says a head of marketing is measured by unprompted awareness tests. A CEO is measured by net profit and quick position and the board is measured by return on assets. Let's clarify some of this. What exactly is a CEO's quick position? And why is the board looking at return on assets?

So, a CEO's quick position is essentially a strict test of the company's immediate liquidity. Like cash on hand. Exactly. It asks if everything went wrong today, do we have the cash on hand right now to survive and pay our immediate liabilities? It measures the CEO's ability to keep the company breathing. Makes sense. And return on assets. Return on assets, which the board watches, measures how efficiently the company is using its equipment, property, or investments to generate profit. It basically asks, are we actually getting a good financial return on the physical things we own?

That completely removes the ambiguity when a marketing ad knows they are measured purely by whether the target audience actually remembers the brand. That unprompted awareness, they stop wasting time on vanity metrics like generic social media likes. Right? It aligns everyone. But there's a methodology in this organizational section I want

to poke at force field analysis. Oh, this is a good way. It says you start by defining the perfect world outcome and then you define the worst world position. You list the forces pushing you toward the goal and the constraints holding you back.

Yep. But there's a specific specific note that says, and I'm quoting here, you're using fear of worst outcome to generate the desire to act now, which is why it needs to linger in their mind. Is wielding fear as a management tool actually healthy? Well, what's fascinating here is if you look at it through the lens of a boss just yelling at employees, it sounds incredibly toxic. Yeah, it sounds awful. But the framework explicitly clarifies that the goal is to play the ball, not the player.

Play the ball, not the player. Meaning, focus on the external issue. Exactly. It's not about the CEO threatening the staff with layoffs. It's about the entire team standing shoulder-to-shoulder looking at the reality of the market. Ah, I see. The worst world outcome might be a new tech startup putting you all out of business. By honestly identifying that shared threat together, you create shared organizational stakes. The fear isn't generated by management. The fear is the reality of a competitive market.

So acknowledging it builds a unified urgent action plan to overcome those external constraints. Exactly. You're uniting the team against the environment rather than each other. You're shining a light on the unknown unknowns together. So, let's look at the terrain we've covered. We've set our targets. We've chartered our strategy in a blue ocean. We've built our marketing funnel based on human psychology. And we've aligned our internal engine. It feels like we're ready to launch. It does. But there is one final overarching piece to this deep dive. The ultimate stress test.

Future proofing. Because no matter how good the plan is today, The market never stops moving, right? How do we ensure that new technology or unseen threats don't make our beautifully planned business obsolete? To answer this, we look at the nine growth aspect questions on innovation. And the prompts here are fascinating. They really are. It asks things like, could you approach a university for research assistance instead of paying corporate rates? And my personal favorite, yeah. Is there technology you could borrow and adapt from other industries?

That is one of the most powerful yet vastly underutilized shortcuts to innovation. But let me play devil's advocate for a second. Borrowing tech from other industries sounds great in a brainstorming session, but aren't you just building a Frankenstein business model? What do you mean? Like you're bolting on software or machinery that wasn't meant for your specific field. Doesn't that get clunky? It can. But this is where Chris Anderson's technology points framework comes in to explain the mechanics of why this is brilliant. Whenever new technology enters a market, it measures at what Anderson

calls the critical price point. It is incredibly expensive because the creators have to cover all their R&D costs and initial sales volumes are low.

So the pioneers take the arrows. They pay the absolute highest cost to figure out all the bugs precisely. But eventually the technology achieves market acceptance. The cost of production drops dramatically and the bigname brands who pioneered it usually capitulate and withdraw in search of the next big thing. Right? If you borrow established proven technology from another sector and apply it to your own like bringing advanced logistics software used by global shipping companies down to a local plumbing business. You completely bypass that expensive R&D phase.

Oh wow. Yeah. You skip the critical price point entirely and gain a massive cost-effective advantage over your local competitors. You're not inventing the wheel. You're just the first person in your specific industry to put the wheel on a cart. I love it. It's incredibly efficient. And that leads directly into the final safety net the light strategies acid test. This is the ultimate evaluation of your ventur's viability. Yes, it asks you to identify the big wall which is the single greatest obstacle to your success and your protection. The moat that literally stops competitors from copying you.

And part of that evaluation means you must be willing to confront some pretty uncomfortable truths about your own limits. So what does this all mean? Let's bring this full circle for you listening. The learner, the ultimate take away from this massive stack of frameworks is that sustainable business growth isn't about blind hustle. No, not at all. It's not about just working 80 hours a week or paddling faster. It's about structured curiosity. By methodically moving through the four domains, targets, strategy, marketing, and organization, you systematically illuminate the unknown unknowns. You find the migraines before you operate on the knee.

And if we look closely at that light strategy asset test, there is one final incredibly jarring question that every listener needs to ponder today. What's that? It's called the rip cord. The rip cord. Yes. We spend all our energy planning for success. We model the revenue. We build the funnels. We design the org charts. But this framework demands that you ask, "How will you identify early failure? How can you collapse the business and get out quickly with minimal damage?" Wow. We love the X-ray when it shows a clean bill of health, but we hate looking at it when the news is bad. So, we leave you with this. You know your plan for growth. You know your targets in your blue ocean. But in whatever project, business, or career pivot you are running right now, what is your rip cord?

Have a plan for the worst so you can confidently build the best. Until next time, keep digging.

Specialist Tools

The following summary relates to content stored in the Specialist Tools section of Advisor-e. This content is designed to help advisors secure advisory engagements with new and existing clients. The content is focused on ADVICE and therefore, is better suited to advisors who have previous experience in running client meetings without supervision and are confident to deliver complex business concepts.

1A.GE. Productive Habits

- **Purpose:** To explain the emotional reactions to learning and change, and to provide a structured "2x5 step method" for building new productive habits.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It helps owners recognize what is "blocking" them from making positive changes, allowing them to turn abstract goals into consistent action plans while navigating the natural shock and avoidance phases of the learning curve.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides the "5 Drivers of Human Output" framework, enabling the advisor to objectively assess and coach a client's performance without lumping observations into a single point of view.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client complains of "getting in their own way," avoids necessary actions or feedback, or struggles to implement positive changes in their life or business.

2. Asset Review 1

- **Purpose:** To audit and rate business assets based on their operational necessity (Vital, Necessary, Useful) and calculate their net value, debt, and utilization.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It provides clarity on which assets are generating enough utilization to service their debt payments and identifies items that should be held or released to free up capital.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It gives the advisor a structured, mathematical way to analyze a client's asset register and advise on capital release potential.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client has cash flow issues, underutilized equipment, high debt tied to physical assets, or needs to restructure their balance sheet.

3. Bizz Sale Assessment Model

- **Purpose:** A comprehensive financial modeling spreadsheet used to calculate a business's adjusted asset values, goodwill, payback periods, and return on investment (ROI) for a sale or purchase.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It grounds their expectations in data, showing both "fair market" and "worst-case" realization values, helping them objectively view what their business is worth.

- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides robust financial calculations—such as EBPITDA multipliers, depreciation, and debt serviceability—to distance valuation advice from arbitrary market guesswork.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client is actively looking to buy a business, sell their business, or needs a data-driven valuation for succession planning.

4. Business Assessment Report

- **Purpose:** A presentation template designed for a **purchaser**, breaking down the fair market value, margin for error, and investment scenarios of a prospective business acquisition.
- **How it helps the business owner (Buyer):** It highlights the potential fragility of the business's ability to service the purchase price during economic declines and outlines risks like lease expiry or staff transferability.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It serves as a structured deliverable to present due diligence findings using "3-Point Sensitivities" (serviceability, goodwill repayment, and performance variance) to ground the buyer's decisions in reality.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** A client is evaluating a specific business to purchase and needs help assessing the risks and securing bank financing.

5. Business Sale Assessment Report

- **Purpose:** A presentation template designed for a **vendor**, demonstrating how a potential purchaser will view their business's value, risks, and future maintainable earnings.
- **How it helps the business owner (Seller):** It empowers the seller to maximize their return by understanding the "bankable price" a purchaser can afford, helping them prepare for negotiations and due diligence.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a framework to manage a seller's "Confirmation Bias" and emotional attachment, bringing their asking price in line with realistic market and funding constraints.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** A client intends to sell their business, needs to establish a defensible asking price, or is seeking a market valuation.

6. Cafe Turnaround Behaviours

- **Purpose:** To provide structural considerations and communication scripts designed to improve customer engagement and handle complaints in a hospitality setting.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It gives them actionable, scenario-based scripts for their staff (e.g., handling a queue vs. a single customer) to improve the customer experience and increase upselling.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It serves as a practical, ready-made training tool for the advisor to run role-play sessions and facilitate behavioral change among the client's frontline team.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** A hospitality client is suffering from poor customer service, low average transaction values (lack of upselling), or negative online reviews.

7. Client Survey

- **Purpose:** A conversational phone script and guide for gathering honest feedback from a client's customer base regarding service expectations and communication.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It cuts through polite "coded language" to uncover real data on service bottlenecks, market differentiation, and areas for immediate improvement.

- **How it helps the advisor:** It allows the advisor to act as an objective, third-party researcher, building trust with the client's market and gathering unbiased data to drive strategic consulting.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client is experiencing customer churn, is unsure of their competitive advantage, or is considering changing their billing/service models.

8. Coping with the types at their worst

- **Purpose:** A psychological guide mapping the 9 Enneagram personality types to their disruptive workplace behaviors, providing specific coping and management strategies.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It provides targeted management techniques (e.g., setting clear boundaries for "Helpers" or separating behavior from the person for "Achievers") to reduce conflict and improve team dynamics.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It helps the advisor navigate client personality clashes and tailor their own consulting approach based on the client's "Finder, Minder, or Grinder" social style.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The workplace suffers from high conflict, poor communication, or the business owner is struggling to manage specific, difficult employees.

9. DD Customer Review

- **Purpose:** A data analysis framework to segment a client's customer base by fee ranges, engagement levels, and individual salesperson performance.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It provides a stark visualization of customer concentration, showing exactly where revenue comes from and highlighting the effectiveness (or underperformance) of specific sales staff.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It gives the advisor hard empirical data to support recommendations on sales training, restructuring fee models, or pruning unprofitable clients.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client has a bloated customer roster, doesn't know their average client fee, or is struggling to manage underperforming sales team members.

10. Farm Succession Metaphor

- **Purpose:** A visual presentation that uses the metaphor of "building a dream home" to explain the steps of the farm succession process.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It simplifies a daunting, emotionally charged transition into logical, non-threatening steps (wish lists, concept drawings, final design), reducing family friction.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It gives the advisor a collaborative, visual framework that appeals to both the left and right sides of the brain, minimizing instinctual "argumentative" reactions from stakeholders.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** Rural or farming clients are preparing to transition the business to the next generation and are experiencing communication breakdowns or entitlement issues.

11. Financial Systems Review

- **Purpose:** A "helicopter view" audit checklist for evaluating a business's internal controls across revenue, expenditure, inventory, IT systems, and payroll.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It identifies operational vulnerabilities to fraud, shrinkage, and inefficiencies, ensuring basic financial safeguards (like blind cash counts or password rotations) are in place.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It acts as a structured discovery tool to assess client risk quickly and recommend deep-dive audits or new system implementations.

- **Appropriate Indicators:** The business relies heavily on manual cash handling, lacks formal delegated authorities, or is experiencing unexplained inventory shrinkage.

12. GE.SMART & FAST Goals

- **Purpose:** A guide to setting SMART goals that emphasizes the psychological importance of "Affect" (emotional connection) and strict timeframes.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It transforms vague daydreams into concrete, actionable steps, ensuring goals are rooted in deep intrinsic motivation rather than simple repetition.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a structured workshop format to elicit a client's true life desires across various categories (financial, physical, spiritual) and align them with their business strategy.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client lacks strategic direction, continually fails to execute on stated business plans, or sets unachievable, open-ended targets.

13. Indicative Value Questions

- **Purpose:** A preliminary questionnaire to gather essential context on a business's history, competitors, threats, opportunities, and key dependencies prior to a valuation.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It forces them to critically assess their market position, their reliance on key people or suppliers, and the true nature of their past expenditures.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It collects the raw, qualitative data required to perform an accurate comparative or asset-based business valuation.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** A client requests a business valuation for the purposes of succession, a partner buyout, or a potential sale.

14. L.Supt.Alignment

- **Purpose:** Explains human motivation theories (Maslow, Alderfer's ERG) and the "5 Domains" to help craft effective Vision, Purpose, Values, Mission, and Strategy statements.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It helps leadership align their "What We Say" with "What We Mean," unifying the team, customers, and community under a coherent culture.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides tools to facilitate a strategic retreat, preventing clients from creating hollow, "narcissistic" corporate statements by grounding them in cognitive patterns.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The company lacks a clear culture, the team is misaligned, or leadership wants to formally redefine their strategic direction.

15. LS.Phone Techniques

- **Purpose:** A training presentation on standardized phone etiquette, shaping business culture, and handling difficult customers using the "H.E.A.T" method.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It establishes a minimum communication standard for the team, empowering them to manage "hotheads" effectively and create a memorable customer experience.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a ready-to-deliver training session, complete with role-play exercises, to immediately add value to a client's frontline staff.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The business has a high rate of customer complaints over the phone, inconsistent team greetings, or frontline staff struggling with angry callers.

16. Managing Poor Performance

- **Purpose:** A formal human resources guide—complete with Performance Improvement Plans (PIPs) and warning letter templates—for legally and fairly managing employee underperformance.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It protects the business from legal risks (such as unjustified dismissal or bullying claims) while providing a structured pathway to either improve or exit the staff member.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It equips the advisor to guide clients through highly stressful HR processes, offering objective steps, sample letters, and advice on handling stress-related claims.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client is frustrated by an underperforming employee, facing staff stress or bullying claims, or is unsure how to legally issue formal warnings.

17. Ratio Analysis

- **Purpose:** A guide on properly assimilating and interpreting financial data using ratio analysis, common size balance sheets, and external benchmarking.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It enables them to understand their true year-on-year performance without being misled by one-off events, seasonal cycles, or starting cash advantages.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a strict methodology to ensure data is "comparing apples with apples" before the advisor formulates strategic recommendations.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client is making decisions based on skewed external benchmark data, misunderstands their financial reports, or experiences highly seasonal business cycles.

18. Remuneration & Incentives

- **Purpose:** A framework for exploring staff reward options (bonuses, profit share, equity, perks) and aligning incentives with desired business behaviors.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It helps them build fair, transparent incentive schemes that drive profitability without accidentally giving away equity or creating an expectation of unearned bonuses.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It allows the advisor to challenge a client's ad-hoc bonus habits and guide them toward structured, measurable output or efficiency rewards.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client wants to stop staff from discounting, needs to retain key talent, or is dangerously considering offering shares to an employee without understanding the pros and cons.

19. Succession Planning

- **Purpose:** An advisor preparation guide for facilitating succession planning, focusing on managing entitlement, conflict, and establishing a collaborative visual framework.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It smooths the transition of power and assets, ensuring that complex issues—like fair market wages for successors, trigger events, and funding requirements—are discussed openly.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It reminds the advisor to act as a *facilitator* rather than an expert dictating advice, using metaphors to bypass the client's instinctual "Argumentative Theory" defense mechanisms.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** An aging business owner is looking to pass the business to family or key staff, bringing a high potential for emotional conflict or complex funding needs.

20. Supplier Survey

- **Purpose:** A conversational phone script and guide to solicit feedback from a business's suppliers regarding communication, industry trends, and product utilization.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It uncovers supply chain inefficiencies, highlights new industry trends the business is missing, and identifies untapped promotional or training opportunities.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It acts as a tool to perform third-party supply chain analysis, helping the advisor build a broader, more objective picture of the client's operational health.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The client has strained supplier relationships, is missing out on market trends, or is experiencing inventory and supply chain bottlenecks.

21. Team Survey

- **Purpose:** A confidential questionnaire designed to uncover internal workflow bottlenecks, delegation opportunities, and gauge overall employee alignment and satisfaction.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It provides uncensored feedback on management performance, role clarity, and cultural health straight from the team.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It serves as a powerful diagnostic tool to kick off a consulting engagement, highlighting immediate operational or HR issues that need addressing.
- **Appropriate Indicators:** The business suffers from high staff turnover, the owner feels overwhelmed and needs to delegate, or there is general operational inefficiency and poor communication.

Summary Table of Templates Listed as Sources

Template / Source Name	Core Subject Matter
1A.GE. Productive Habits	Building habits and overcoming the emotional reactions to change.
Asset Review 1	Rating business assets to assess utilization and capital release potential.
Bizz Sale Assessment Model	Financial modeling spreadsheet for business valuation and payback calculations.
Business Assessment Report	Presentation for a <i>buyer</i> to evaluate the risks and value of a business purchase.

Business Sale Assessment Report	Presentation for a <i>seller</i> to establish a defensible asking price and manage expectations.
Cafe Turnaround Behaviours	Hospitality scripts for customer engagement, upselling, and handling complaints.
Client Survey	Phone script to gather honest feedback from a client's customers.
Coping with the types at their worst.	Managing disruptive workplace behaviors using the 9 Enneagram personality types.
DD Customer Review	Analyzing customer profitability, engagement, and salesperson effectiveness.
Farm Succession Metaphor	Visual metaphor ("building a dream home") to manage farm succession smoothly.
Financial Systems Review	High-level audit checklist for revenue, expenditure, inventory, IT, and payroll.
GE.SMART & FAST Goals	Setting actionable goals with emotional drivers and strict timeframes.
Indicative Value Questions	Preliminary questionnaire to gather contextual data for a business valuation.
L.Suppt.Alignment	Crafting aligned Vision, Purpose, Values, Mission, and Strategy statements.

LS.Phone Techniques	Frontline training for phone etiquette and dealing with angry customers (H.E.A.T).
Managing Poor Performance	HR guide and templates for formal Performance Improvement Plans and warnings.
Ratio Analysis	Interpreting financial data accurately using ratios and common size reporting.
Remuneration & Incentives	Framework for fair staff bonuses, profit sharing, and exploring equity pros/cons.
Succession Planning	Advisor guide to facilitating succession discussions and managing family conflict.
Supplier Survey	Phone script to gather feedback and spot market trends from a client's suppliers.
Team Survey	Internal questionnaire to uncover operational bottlenecks and staff satisfaction.

What if I told you that focusing on your company's overarching why we why is um actually fueling narcissism and slowly destroying your team's culture? Or, you know, consider this. What if giving a massive output-based performance bonus to your top creative talent is statistically guaranteed to make them worse at their jobs? I mean, those concepts sound completely backwards if you've spent like any time reading standard business literature over the last decade. We are so conditioned to reward output and to uh endlessly workshop our corporate purpose, right? Which is exactly why we're here. Welcome to the deep dive. Our mission today is to show you how a very specific stack of internal business templates and diagnostic tools makes delivering advanced advisory services or honestly just managing a business effectively so much easier.

Yeah. They act as a shortcut.

Exactly. They take overwhelming chaotic business problems and turn them into structured solvable steps. And you know, they do it by aggressively challenging a lot of what we consider common sense. And the sheer range of what these templates cover is just um it's a treasure trove. We are looking at a complete ecosystem for analyzing a company.

A whole ecosystem. Yeah.

Right. So the sources begin with psychological habit building frameworks and these highly specific culture defining phone scripts and then they pivot straight into hardcore financial ratio analyses and business valuation sensitivities.

Okay, let's unpack this because I noticed the templates don't actually start with spreadsheets, or you know profit and loss statements, they start with the absolute most unpredictable variable in any business operation: human behavior.

Yeah. The structural philosophy here is that an adviser has to map individual performance and psychology before they can even like attempt to fix the wider business. So the templates start by charting out the emotional reaction to learning.

Which is usually messy.

Very messy. When a new system or change is introduced the immediate reaction from a client or an employee isn't progress it's shock.

Right and we usually expect a straight line to success like we implement a new software, we learn a lesson, we get better.

But the template explicitly outlines a nonlinear learning curve. That initial shock quickly dips into a phase they label avoidance.

Oh, avoidance. Yeah, that makes sense.

And only after navigating those deep uh emotional valleys do individuals reach acceptance and finally testing and implementation. The psychological reaction is the single biggest obstacle to moving forward, completely independent of how good the new business strategy actually is.

You know, it sounds like upgrading a smartphone's operating system.

How do you mean?

Well, you hit install and for the next day, the phone constantly glitches, right? The battery drains fast, the interface slows down. That's the shock and avoidance phase.

Oh, that's a great way to look at it.

The phone has to reorganize its internal architecture before it settles in and actually runs better. And if an adviser or manager doesn't anticipate that glitching phase, they'll just assume the update is broken and abandon it entirely.

Exactly. And to get through that, glitching phase, the templates get incredibly granular. They outline five mechanical steps to building new habits.

Okay, what are they?

Reason, trigger, micro habit, effective practice, and plan. And they ground this in a very visceral example of a smoker trying to quit.

Right? A classic habit breaking scenario.

Right? So the smoker doesn't just declare they are quitting entirely. They drop from two packs a day down to five cigarettes. That is the micro habit.

Just a small achievable step. So how does the effective practice step work in that scenario?

So when the smoker encounters a trigger, they drink a glass of water and visualize it cleansing their lungs. They are literally instructed to picture their lungs like a freshly washed car that they don't want to get dirty.

Oh wow. So it's very visual.

Extremely visual. It forces a connection between a physiological craving and a protective emotional visualization. And then the plan step zooms way out. They commit to running a half marathon in 12 months, visualizing a newborn child greeting them at the finish line.

But I mean, real life is rarely that clean, right? Yeah. What happens when you have this great plan to implement a new service in your business, but then a massive unexpected client deadline hits?

Well, the templates classify those as interference triggers.

Interference triggers.

Right? Normal work deadlines run interference and sabotage the new habit. So, the framework requires you to anticipate the feelings associated with those old triggers before they happen. So, the default reaction isn't to just abandon the new system.

It's all about anticipating the roadblocks.

Exactly. And this psychological deep dive even extends into personality profiling, specifically how to manage different types when they are under stress.

Right. They bring up anyagram type fives, the investigators, like the really perceptive cerebral members of a team.

Yeah. And at their best, type fives are visionary pioneers. But under stress, the template warns that they become detached, high-rung, and prone to isolation or even nihilism.

Wow. Nihilism. That's intense for a workplace.

It is. But you simply cannot manage a stressed type five the same way you manage a highly extroverted stressed salesperson. The diagnostic tools even rewrite the traditional smart goals framework to account for this human emotion.

Right? Usually the ANR stand for achievable and realistic. So how do these templates redefine them?

Well, in this system, the A stands for effect, meaning you must be able to directly influence the outcome yourself and it must have a strong emotional effect on you.

So you have to care about it.

Deeply. You have to articulate exactly how you will feel if you achieve it and how you will feel if you fail. And then the R is relative.

Relative to what?

To your other goals. It forces the user to look at how failing to achieve one goal will starve another goal of resources or confidence. The goals are mapped as interdependent dominoes rather than, you know, isolated targets.

Okay, I have to stop you there because if you're listening to this and you run, say, a logistics company or an accounting firm, you might be thinking, Um, I don't have time to play psychologist with anyagrams and visualization exercises. Shouldn't a business adviser be looking at cash flow?

I hear that all the time. But an individual psychology directly creates the company's culture. You literally cannot scale a business if the individuals inside it aren't aligned.

So, the financials reflect the psychology.

Exactly. The cash flow problems you see on a spreadsheet are almost always lagging symptoms of behavioral problems on the floor. And these tools pivot from individual psychology directly into formalizing team culture starting with what they call the five domains.

Okay. The five domains. Walk me through how those actually interact.

Sure. So being is your identity. Knowing is your purpose or your knowledge. Relating is your connection to others. Having refers to your resources. And doing is the actual execution.

Okay? Being, knowing, relating, having, doing.

Right? And the templates offer a very sharp critique of current business fashion right here. They argue that the modern obsession with discovering your WY, which falls under the knowing domain, is often a fuel for narcissistic tendencies.

I mean, calling the search for your company's YI narcissistic, is a pretty bold statement. Everyone talks about finding your why.

They really do. But the logic here is entirely mechanics-based. Focusing solely on your why ignores the interdependent enabling domains, specifically the how and the doing.

Oh, I see.

Yeah. If a leadership team sits around obsessing over their grand worldchanging purpose, but completely ignores the strategy, the resource allocation and the daily grind of execution. They aren't building a culture. They are just feeding their own egos.

That makes a lot of sense. So, how do they define culture? Then the templates define culture not as a mission statement but as a social contract of permissions.

A social contract. So, it's the spoken and unspoken rules about how a group behaves together to make everyone feel safe and productive.

Exactly. And they enforce this social contract in the most mundane place. cases like um answering the phone,

Which seems so basic,

But the basics dictate the culture. If your social contract claims your team is attentive and professional, your mission statement is totally irrelevant if the phone rings 10 times and someone answers it sounding exhausted,

Right? So, what's the rule?

The templates dictate that phones must be answered in exactly three to four rings. Not one ring because then the business sounds desperate or like the staff has literally nothing else to do, but no more than four. They also provide a structural mechanism for when that social contract is tested by say a furious customer using the HAT method. Right here, empathize, apologize, take responsibility.

That's the one. First, hear them without interrupting. Empathize by trying to walk in their shoes without throwing up defensive walls,

Which is hard to do when someone is yelling at you.

It's incredibly hard. Then you apologize, even if you are only apologizing for the way the situation has made them feel. And finally, take responsibility by outlining specific actions and time frames. And to ensure these habits stick, the templates introduce a role called the enforcer.

Yes, the enforcer. But wait, how does appointing an enforcer not just create massive office politics and resentment? Like nobody wants a hall monitor at work

Because the team explicitly agrees on the role beforehand. It takes the personal friction out of the equation.

Oh, so it's sanctioned by the group.

Exactly. It isn't just a coworker nagging you about answering the phone too slowly. It is the designated enforcer executing the job the entire team agreed was necessary to maintain the social contract.

Okay, so moving from culture to compensation, the renumeration rules in these documents are fascinating to me because they run contrary to almost every modern incentive program. They have a golden rule regarding the complexity of a task.

They do. For complex tasks that require variety and cognitive flexibility, the templates state you must never use output bonuses.

Never.

Never. Repeated behavioral studies show that for complex work, an output-based financial incentive actually decreases performance.

So what is the psychological mechanism behind that? Like why would offering someone more money make them worse at solving a complex problem?

It creates tunnel vision. When you tie a significant financial reward to a specific output, the brain narrows its focus to find the absolute quickest path to the money.

So they just look for shortcuts,

Right? It bypasses creative lateral thinking entirely. And for complex problem solving, you need a wide, flexible perspective. So, the template advises paying a fair, robust salary to just take the issue of money off the table. Then provide a clear learning path and give the employee autonomy over their daily tasks.

Wait, if you tell a high performing operations director or a lead designer that they aren't getting a bonus this year because their job is too complex. I mean, they're going to quit tomorrow. How does the template justify that to a board of directors?

By leaning on intrinsic motivation. Once a highle employee is paid enough that they aren't worried about their mortgage. Their motivation naturally shifts toward mastery, autonomy, and purpose.

So, when do you use output bonuses?

They are strictly reserved for highly repeatable mechanical tasks. The example the templates use is screwing toothpaste lids on.

Toothpaste lids.

Yeah. The more lids you screw on, the more profit the business makes, and absolutely no creativity is required. So, you bonus that out all day long.

But, you know, the intrinsic motivation model only works if the business is financially viable enough to pay those high base salaries in the first place. You can't pay a premium salary if the company's bleeding cash,

Which is the harsh reality. A perfectly aligned culture with autonomous employees is totally useless if the math doesn't work. This is where the adviser must pivot from soft skills and psychology to hard data tools. And the templates map out a five-step advisory staircase for this transition, right?

Compilation, assimilation, interpretation, application, and observation.

That's the staircase. And they highlight a massive rookie mistake that happens right in the interpretation phase specifically regarding external benchmark data.

Oh, right. Explain that because it seems like benchmark data is everywhere now.

It is. Many advisers try to compare a client's business to industry averages before they even know how the client's own business works. They purchase external benchmark data before quantifying internal business assumptions.

But why is that dangerous? I mean, if the industry average margin is 20%, shouldn't you know that immediately?

Because you aren't comparing apples with apples. If you buy a report stating the average margin is 20%. But you don't realize that benchmark includes businesses with entirely different accounting methods or different local labor markets or different seasonal cycles than your client, then the data is useless. Worse than useless, it's highly misleading. You end up setting goals based on a phantom competitor.

That concept of being misled by data brings us to the heaviest element in these sources, business valuations. When an adviser uses these templates to assess a business for sale. They don't just look at a revenue multiple and call it a day.

Not at all.

They demand three reality checks which they call the three-point sensitivities.

Right? And these sensitivities strip the emotion out of buying or selling a business. The first is the bankable price. Can a commercial loan actually service the purchase price?

So basically, what will a bank actually fund?

Exactly. It calculates the highest probable finance threshold factoring in a risk assessment interest rate cover that the historic cash flow can afford. If a bank won't fund it based on the actual cash available to service the debt, the asking price is just a fantasy.

Okay? And the second sensitivity is the goodwill repayment period. But before we get into the math on that, let's define the term for everyone. Goodwill is essentially the premium you pay for a business's reputation, its brand, and its existing customer base. It's the intangible value above and beyond the physical equipment and inventory.

Spot on. And the Goodwill repayment sensitivity is an absolute ego killer for a buyer.

Why an ego killer?

Because it compares the investment of buying the business against putting that same money into a low-risk cash term deposit and just going to get a regular job.

Oh, wow. So, it's a reality check on your own time.

Exactly. It forces the buyer to ask, "How many years am I willing to work for just wages while all the super profits of the business go toward paying off the goodwill I bought from the previous owner?"

It frames the purchase as a brutal comparison of your own time versus alternative options. And the third sensitivity is performance variance, right? Which ensures projected net profits are within a realistic variance so the buyer doesn't project massive future growth without hard historical evidence,

Right? It stops you from getting drunk on the Kool-Aid. And speaking of getting drunk on the numbers, the templates also dedicate a special note to a valuation trap that is incredibly common and financially devastating. The hyperinflation valuation trap.

Yes. It comes down to confusing an EBIDT multiple with a goodwill multiple.

Okay, let's break that acronym down. EBIDT stands for earnings before proprietors income, interest, depreciation, and tax.

Right? So, let's walk through the math of how this trap happens. Independent data providers often supply an EBIDT multiple based on total historic business sales.

Okay, so total sales.

Yes. Let's say a business earns \$100,000 and the data says similar businesses sold for a three times EBPI multiple. That means the total value of the business should \$300,000.

That sounds straightforward enough,

But rookie advisers mistakenly use that total EBPI multiple as just the goodwill multiple. So the adviser says, "Okay, the goodwill alone is worth \$300,000. Now let's add the value of the equipment, say \$100,000 and the inventory another \$50,000."

Oh no.

They just valued the business at \$450,000.

Wow. So using the wrong multiples like buying a furnished house, but the seller charges you for the house based on comparable neighborhood sales and then charges you entirely separately for the furniture that was already factored into those comparable sales. The buyer is paying for the tangible assets twice.

It is a catastrophic financial landmine by applying a multiple intended for the entire sale price just to the earnings and then stacking tangible assets on top of it. The adviser accidentally hyperinflates the value.

That is why

And avoiding landmines like that is exactly what makes a templated system so valuable. You don't have to remember the intricacies of the math. The template forces you to categorize the assets correctly.

But you know, valuing the business is really only half the battle because the final step in these sources is planning the actual exit or the turnaround. Which brings us to future proofing. I mean, why does a high valuation even matter if the business falls apart the moment the founder retires?

It doesn't. It's completely meaningless. And that's why the templates force the advisor to navigate the highly emotional phases of succession planning.

Yeah. a business down is rarely simple.

Never simple. The framework requires asking questions that routinely cause family arguments. Starting with the fair market rate,

Right? Meaning, has the successor, for example, say a founder's son who has been working in the warehouse for 10 years, been paid a fair market rate for his work during that time?

Yes. And if he was underpaid, has a discount been applied to the final purchase price to compensate him for his sweat equity?

Man, that single question can uncover a decade of hidden resentment?

Oh, absolutely. The templates also look for trigger events to speed up the succession plan and they demand a contingency for trauma.

Trauma like what?

Like what happens if the chosen successor experiences a major medical event or simply decides they want to change their life path and move to another country? What is the backup plan?

And if there are multiple siblings involved, how are disparate financial figures managed without causing a family war?

The templates require the current owner to document the valuation methodology and get everyone to agree to the math before any money changes hands.

But future proofing isn't just about succession though. It is about systematizing the behavior of the staff to guarantee the revenue, which in turn guarantees that high valuation multiple we talked about. So how do you systematize staff behavior at that level?

Well, the templates pull us all the way back from high level succession down to the absolute granular level of a cafe turnaround script.

We've literally gone from multi-million dollar valuation landmines to upselling cake at a coffee shop.

We have because the underlying philosophy is identical. Systematize the behavior to guarantee the outcome. If a business only makes money because the charismatic founder is standing behind the register, the business is worthless to a buyer. So, the template maps out exactly what the lowest level employee should say, dictated entirely by the customer's level of engagement, making the revenue owner agnostic.

Okay. So, if the customer is fully engaged, like they're joking, laughing, asking the to questions. The script dictates a direct upsell. Like, are you going to reward yourself with a cake to go with that coffee?

Exactly. The report is already established, so permission to sell has been granted.

But if the customer is only semi-engaged, maybe they're just smiling politely and placing their order. The script softens to a lower pressure approach. Does anything else grab your fancy today?

And if the customer is not engaged at all, they are abrupt, looking at their phone, and just want to pay the template, tells the staff to back off. safely. Okay, that's just the coffee for now. Maybe we could tempt you with a muffin next time.

It completely removes the guesswork for the employee. It prevents them from annoying an impatient customer, but it guarantees the business won't miss a high probability sales opportunity with a happy one. So, what does this all mean for you as the listener? We've gone from the deep psychology of any lung visualizations to the mechanics of output bonuses to double charging for business assets down to upselling cake. How does a business adviser or an owner keep all of these mechanics straight in their head?

They don't. That is the true magic of the system. By trusting these templates, the adviser is freed from having to memorize everything. The templates carry the cognitive load of the business mechanics.

It's like outsourcing your memory to the framework.

Exactly. When the spreadsheet is doing the complex multiple calculations and the scripts are handling the sales floor, the adviser is free to focus entirely on the client's human experience. You can guide a client through the shock and avoidance of major change because you aren't simultaneously trying to calculate goodwill repayment periods in your head.

These templates prove that advanced advisory isn't about being a solitary genius who walks into a boardroom with all the answers memorized. It's about having the right diagnostic tools to ask the right questions at exactly the right time.

Yeah, it's taking those vague whiteboard diagrams and replacing them with a blueprint that actually shows you how to lay the bricks. So, we've seen how these templates systemize almost everything from human habits to financial valuations. But it raises an important question for you to explore on your own.

Yeah, think about this. If every aspect of your business operations, your culture, and your financial behavior can be mapped, measured, and templated, what is the one untlatable spark in your own work that a competitor could never replicate? Find your spark and let the templates handle the rest. Thank you so much for joining us on this deep dive. We'll see you next time.

Governance Tools

The following summary relates to content stored in the Governance / Board Pack section of Advisor-e. This content is designed to help advisors secure advisory engagements with new and existing clients. The content is a combination of

FACILITATION, EDUCATION & ADVICE and therefore, is better suited to advisors who have previous experience in running client meetings without supervision and are confident to deliver complex business concepts.

1. 6 Hats Thinking

- **Purpose:** A collaborative framework designed by Edward De Bono to guide "parallel thinking" and overcome argumentative theory and confirmation bias. It uses different "hats" to focus discussions on logic, emotion, caution, optimism, creativity, and organization.
- **How it helps the business owner:** It aligns the team to focus on the same topic from the same perspective simultaneously, increasing the effectiveness of planning sessions tenfold and preventing well-meaning individuals from working at cross purposes.
- **How it helps the advisor:** It provides a structured, guided tool to facilitate client discussions, ensuring everyone contributes and discussions remain focused and productive.
- **Indicators for use:** The client indicates a need to improve their "decision quality" rather than rule adherence, or meetings frequently derail due to conflicting problem-solving approaches.

2. Agenda & Notes

- **Purpose:** A simple, recurring meeting template to allocate time for specific topics, track action plan progress, and note key takeaways.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Allows leaders to routinely check financial performance, assess what has gone well or less well, and formalize the main lessons from the meeting.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Offers a straightforward mechanism for holding clients accountable during regular touchpoints by structuring review sessions.
- **Indicators for use:** The client struggles with tracking task status between meetings, or their basic management meetings lack a consistent feedback loop.

3. Annual Board Plan

- **Purpose:** A yearly matrix mapping out strategic meeting topics (e.g., Scenario Planning, CEO Performance Review, Budgets) month-by-month, alongside required reports and board pack requirements.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Ensures that no critical element of strategic governance or compliance is missed over the financial year.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Provides a roadmap to assist the client in transitioning from ad-hoc meetings to a structured, professional governance rhythm.
- **Indicators for use:** The client suffers from a lack of formal protocols, or their board needs to improve "rule adherence and accountability".

4. Board Member Conduct

- **Purpose:** A framework to identify a team's functioning levels, highlight boardroom manipulation tactics (like the "Bully" or "Turtle Mentality"), and establish a firm code of conduct.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Promotes self-awareness and helps directors check their egos, align with common goals, and embrace healthy brainstorming and respect.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Gives the advisor an objective tool to address toxic boardroom dynamics, implement "safe words" to manage conduct, and foster authentic contribution.
- **Indicators for use:** The board suffers from "Poor Member Conduct," internal drama, manipulation, or entrenched ego-driven conflicts.

5. Board Pack Tables

- **Purpose:** A checklist designed to track meeting agendas, previous minutes, CEO/Financial reports, and major correspondence, ensuring materials are read and understood.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Enforces accountability for meeting preparation, ensuring directors don't waste time reading during the session.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Helps establish a pre-meeting preparation discipline for clients moving toward formal governance.
- **Indicators for use:** The client complains about unprepared directors, or the business lacks reliable protocols for distributing and reviewing board papers.

6. BoardPack.Agenda

- **Purpose:** A highly detailed board meeting agenda breaking down exactly how many minutes are allocated to each item (e.g., PI Notifications, Matters Arising, CEO Report).
- **How it helps the business owner:** Professionalizes the board meeting structure and keeps discussions strictly within the total allocated time.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Allows the advisor to teach the client (or Chair) how to effectively corral meeting time and guide discussions efficiently.
- **Indicators for use:** The client's meetings regularly run over time, or they are just beginning to formalize board meeting procedures and lack protocols.

7. BoardPack.WP Guide (White Paper Guidelines)

- **Purpose:** A structural guide for writing white papers, outlining how to format executive summaries, define the problem/opportunity, provide historical context, suggest solutions, and measure benefits.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Helps them clearly articulate business cases, secure vendor agreements, or pitch strategic solutions supported by feasibility data.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Provides a tool to help the client clarify their thinking and draft sound strategic proposals.
- **Indicators for use:** The client needs to improve decision quality and needs to present well-researched, feasible solutions or alternatives to the board.

8. Conflicts of Interest Disclosure

- **Purpose:** A legal tracking template for directors to declare outside financial interests, directorships, or relationships with suppliers.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Safeguards the company from biased decision-making and ensures compliance by formally documenting potential conflicts.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Facilitates the implementation of essential risk management and compliance procedures within the client's board.
- **Indicators for use:** The client lacks formal board protocols, or they are onboarding new directors to a formal board.

9. Governance Introduction

- **Purpose:** An educational presentation explaining the pillars of governance, the difference between an advisory board and a board of directors, and the basics of CEO reporting.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Demystifies governance concepts, helping them decide if they need an advisory board (as a stepping stone) or a formal board of directors.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Serves as a perfect onboarding or pitching tool to help clients understand what governance is, and the systems required for business success.

- **Indicators for use:** The client states "We need to improve our Governance" focusing on adherence and accountability, but currently has little to no formal understanding of the subject.

10. Governance Playsheet

- **Purpose:** A diagnostic map that guides users to the correct framework depending on the client's specific governance problems (Decision Quality vs. Adherence).
- **How it helps the business owner:** Ensures their core problem is diagnosed correctly so that the interventions applied actually solve their underlying issues.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Acts as an operational flowchart, visually directing the advisor to deploy tools like 6 Hats, White Papers, or Board Plans based on client feedback.
- **Indicators for use:** To be used internally by the advisor when first assessing a client's need to improve governance or if a client shows signs that management is too ineffective for governance to begin.

11. Leadership Review

- **Purpose:** A self-reflection questionnaire examining leadership style, cultural alignment (creativity vs. discipline), and inclusivity.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Encourages deep introspection about how their ego and personal traits influence team diversity, meetings, and business culture.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Opens up strategic coaching conversations with the business owner regarding their management style and handling of conflict.
- **Indicators for use:** The client struggles with staff retention, low team morale, lacks diversity in thought, or insists on being right over finding the best solution.

12. Quality Decisions

- **Purpose:** A comprehensive training presentation exploring common "psyche errors" (like optimism bias and confirmation bias), how to properly interpret data (causation vs. correlation), and how to create frameworks for robust testing.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Teaches them to avoid relying on faulty memory or bias, enabling them to test assumptions through methods like double-blind surveys, and ultimately turning quality decision-making into a habit.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Allows the advisor to deeply educate clients on statistical interpretation (common vs. special causes) and the psychological pitfalls of business expansion.
- **Indicators for use:** The client's business is experiencing complex growth phases, they regularly misinterpret feedback data, or they need structured mechanisms to evaluate "quality decisions".

13. Resolutions

- **Purpose:** Formal legal templates to document board votes on major actions, such as purchasing a helicopter or private jet, launching a company, paying dividends, or raising capital.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Keeps the company legally compliant by securing signed proof of unanimous or majority authorization for significant financial events.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Provides pre-formatted language to help clients efficiently execute required corporate documentation.

- **Indicators for use:** The client operates a formal board and is preparing to authorize high-stakes financial movements, capital raises, or major asset acquisitions.

14. EF.Risk Mgt Cover

- **Purpose:** A formal 5-step risk management process and visual matrix designed to help teams establish context, identify, evaluate, and determine strategies for business risks.
- **How it helps the business owner:** Enables them to systematically assess risks based on probability (likelihood) and consequence (loss). It helps them apply targeted strategies—such as reducing, avoiding, accepting, or transferring the risk to a third party—and formulate concrete contingency and disaster recovery plans.
- **How it helps the advisor:** Provides a structured framework to guide clients through brainstorming and evaluating risks. It allows the advisor to tie risks back to the client's strategic plan or SWOT analysis and hold them accountable by developing an action plan detailing the task, who is responsible, and when it will be completed.
- **Indicators for use:** The client needs to develop contingency or disaster recovery plans, or they require a structured way to evaluate and mitigate emerging threats and liabilities based on their potential impact.

Summary Table of Templates

Template Name	Core Purpose
6 Hats Thinking	A collaborative parallel thinking framework for making quality decisions.
Agenda & Notes	A standardized meeting review form to track actions, KPIs, and takeaways.
Annual Board Plan	A yearly schedule mapping strategic governance topics month-by-month.
Board Member Conduct	A guide and code of conduct addressing boardroom dynamics, ego, and manipulation.

Board Pack Tables	Tracking matrix to ensure meeting documents are distributed and reviewed.
BoardPack.Agenda	A strictly timed, structured agenda format for formal board meetings.
BoardPack.WP Guide	Guidelines for drafting white papers for business cases and solutions.
Conflicts of Interest	A legal declaration form tracking director financial interests and affiliations.
Governance Introduction	An educational presentation outlining board duties, structures, and CEO reporting.
Governance Playsheet	A diagnostic flowchart to determine the right governance tools for a client.
Leadership Review	A questionnaire for analyzing the business owner's leadership style and culture.
Quality Decisions	A training deck on cognitive biases, interpreting data correctly, and robust testing.
Resolutions	Legal templates for documenting official board votes on major financial actions.
EF.Risk Mgt Cover	A formal 5-step evaluation process and matrix for identifying and strategizing business risks.

Think about uh the last time you were in a meeting that just completely went off the rails. Voices were raised, passive aggressive comments were flying across the table. People were digging their heels in. And well, absolutely nothing productive got done.

Oh yeah, we've all been there.

Right now, imagine if someone handed you a manual not on how to print a better agenda, but on how to actually hack the raw psychology of the people in that room to force a good decision.

That's the dream, honestly.

Welcome to our deep dive. Our mission today is to explore a massive, incredibly comprehensive stack of governance training resources. We're looking at, you know, dozens of templates, slide decks, frameworks, tons of material.

Yeah. But our goal here is to uncover what makes this specific collection so radically different from your standard kind of dry corporate compliance pack.

And it really is um a massive departure from the norm because traditional resources, they give you the procedural mechanics, the engine of a board, so to speak. But Whether you're leading a startup, sitting on a local community committee, or just trying to survive a weekly crossf functional team meeting, knowing how the engine works is totally useless if you don't understand the person behind the wheel. You uh you really have to understand the human element.

So, we're talking about the driver, not just the vehicle.

Exactly.

Because most manuals will tell you like the exact tire pressure and oil viscosity your car needs. They give you all the structures, but they tell you absolutely nothing about how to stop the driver from getting road rage, ignoring the speed limit, and just crashing that perfectly tuned machine straight into a ditch.

And that psychological focus is woven into the very foundation of these materials. I mean, if we look at where governance even comes from, the origin of the word govern traces back to the Latin term gubernari, right? Which literally translates to to steer. The gubinator was the pilot of the ship.

Oh, that makes sense.

Yeah. And there's this really powerful grounding quote early in the introductory materials from Brian Dicki. He's a crown prosecutor who dealt heavily with the fallout of failed finance companies.

Okay.

He states quite bluntly, the facade of governance will not act as a shield. He goes on to say, it's not about the structure and procedures, it's about the quality of the decisions.

Okay, let's unpack this because if governance is fundamentally about the quality of decisions, then having a beautifully formatted spreadsheet means absolutely nothing if the people reading it are well acting out.

Yeah, exactly.

We have to look at the biggest obstacle to good decision-making and unfortunately that obstacle is us. It's the flawed ego-driven human being sitting around the table.

It really is. And the materials begin that psychological exploration with a quote from Socrates. Actually, to know thyself is the beginning of wisdom.

I like that.

Right. To make a quality decision, you have to understand the fragile ego that's making it. The training breaks down what it calls the levels of ego acting out in a boardroom.

Okay. What does that look like well they contrast a healthy functional environment with what happens when human insecurities take the wheel. For instance, they define level five ego behavior as interpersonal control.

Interpersonal control, so manipulating others.

Basically, it's where a person or an entire faction of a board is dominated entirely by self-interest. They only care about getting their own personality needs met.

Like uh wanting to look like the smartest person in the room.

Yes. Or desperately trying to justify a past mistake and they will do it at the direct expense of others.

Oh man, that is the person who completely derails a critical strategy meeting just to prove they were right about a minor email sent like 3 weeks ago. Yes.

If it paralyzes the whole room, it does. And if left unchecked, that level five control degrades into level six, which the sources categorize as disruptive positions.

That sounds intense.

It is. At this stage, the ego explodes. The situation goes from being uncomfortably tense to being characterized by a frequent drama, simmering resentments, aggressive outbursts, professional boundaries are completely broken down, and the meeting just becomes a battlefield.

And what makes this resource so engaging is that it doesn't just leave these concepts as, you know, abstract psychology. The sources dive into incredibly specific almost cinematic personas.

Oh, the manipulation tactics.

Yeah, the boardroom manipulation tactics that people use when those egos take over.

I want to walk through a few of these because anyone listening will instantly recognize these characters.

Oh, definitely.

First, there's the assassin. This is the person who deliberately engages in divisive tactics behind the scenes. They build secret personality alliances before the meeting even starts, fueling this toxic hus against them culture.

It's highly destructive because it shifts the focus from solving a business problem to winning a turf war.

Exactly.

Then you have the passive aggressive. Instead of arguing their point on the merits, they just sulk, fold their arms, and radiate negative energy to completely shut down the discussion. Oh, I hate that. Everyone ends up walking on eggshells, right? And the idea dies not because it was bad, but because nobody wanted to deal with the sulking.

Yeah. Then there is one that I see all the time, which is cold logic.

On the surface, this sounds like a good thing, but the sources define this as a manipulation tactic specifically aimed at discrediting creative discussion.

Right. Using logic as a weapon.

Exactly. The person uses weaponized rationality to attack the presenter. shutting down any out of the box thinking under the guise of, you know, just being logical.

It's basically an intimidation tactic dressed up as intellectual rigor.

Yeah.

The list continues with the fence mener. That's the member who abstains from making any authentic contribution whatsoever. They're simply going along to get along, just trying to keep everyone happy, which sounds nice, but but a board isn't a social club. It requires real scrutiny. A fence mener is a massive liability when the business is heading toward a cliff and nobody wants to be the one to sound the alarm.

We also have the donkey, which is the person who stubbornly digs their heels in and refuses to budge regardless of how much new evidence is presented. Their ego is entirely tied to their original stance. Yep.

And my personal favorite, the taxi driver.

This is the member who blindly steers the discussion in absolutely any direction, bringing up completely irrelevant tangents just to frustrate everyone around them.

Hijacking the meeting's direction is their ultimate power play.

Totally.

Which ties heavily into the leadership review section of the materials. It forces a leader to ask a very hard uncomfortable question of their own psychology which is how do you cope when team members disagree with your opinion? Are you guilty of wanting to be right more than you want the best answer?

Oh, that's a tough one to answer honestly because if the leader acting like a donkey or an assassin, the entire governance structure just collapses.

Okay, but here is where it gets really interesting. In the section detailing all these manipulation tactics, There's an action exercise, right? The safe word.

Yeah. It suggests that the team reads through the tactics list together and then decides on a safe word. Now, I have to push back here. Are we seriously saying a corporate boardroom full of seasoned executives needs a safe word like they're in some bad sitcom? It feels a bit silly.

I know it sounds absurd at first glance, but the underlying mechanism is actually quite brilliant.

Oh, so the resource recommends keeping that list of manipulation tactics physically visible during meetings. The agreed upon safe word isn't a joke. It's a structural mechanism to deescalate conflict.

Okay.

When an executive is in the middle of an ego flare up, their rational brain is essentially offline. If you say, "You're being a taxi driver right now," they will instantly become defensive.

Sure, it feels like an attack, right? But a neutral safe politely helps members catch themselves. It separates the behavior from the person. It triggers a moment of self-reflection against the visible list, neutralizing the tension. about a direct personal attack.

So, it serves as a circuit breaker for a heated argument. I can see how that works.

Mhm.

Okay. So, let's assume a board has instituted a safe word and they've successfully identified and neutralized all that intentional ego-driven manipulation. The ram is calm.

Okay.

Are they in the clear to make a good decision?

Far from it. Because once you remove intentional manipulation, you uncover the unintentional mental trap, the unconscious stuff.

Yes. Even perfectly Well-meaning people who have left their egos at the door fail when their internal cognitive wiring goes ar-y.

The sources address this in a module referencing six hats thinking. For those unfamiliar, this is a concept where different colored hats represent different ways of looking at a problem.

Exactly.

The white hat looks purely at data. The red hat looks at emotion and intuition. The black hat looks for flaws and risks. And the yellow hat looks for optimistic benefits.

And the sources point out a huge problem here. Even two people who want the exact same positive outcome for the business will trip over each other simply because one is wearing a black hat and the other is wearing a yellow hat.

They're speaking different cognitive languages, right? And those internal processing differences lead directly into what the resource calls psyche errors. These are the silent cognitive biases that degrade decision quality without anyone noticing.

Right? Like uh they highlight optimism bias. Now optimism generally sounds like a required trait for any business leader. You have to believe you can succeed.

Yes. But Yet in the context of governance, it's often a survival mechanism gone drastically wrong.

How do they define it?

They define optimism bias as our tendency to literally delete negative information to hold on to what we have.

Delete it.

Yeah. Let's say a board is funding a new software roll out. The beta tests are failing miserably. Costs are skyrocketing. But the board ignores those red flags. Acknowledging the negative data threatens their security and their attachment to the project. So their brains simply filter it out.

That leads right into Another major psyche error which is confirmation bias. The sources explain this is driven by cognitive dissonance. To avoid the severe anxiety of feeling like we might have made a catastrophic mistake, we actively search only for shared views that support our current reality.

We surround ourselves with people who tell us the software launch is going great.

Exactly. Suppressing our growing fears by just repeating the same mistakes.

The materials also put a heavy emphasis on the mere exposure. effect which is also known as the familiarity principle.

That's when boards choose the safe known over the unknown. Right.

Yes. They allocate their energy, time and money to keeping what they have rather than achieving what they actually need.

The sources use some really great metaphors for this. They talk about the turtle mentality withdrawing into the shell of the familiar the moment things get scary and the lab rat mentality, right? Where a team just keeps running the exact same familiar maze over and over again out of sheer habit even though the cheese was moved months ago.

It's the reason companies like Blockbuster failed to adapt to streaming. The familiar pain of a declining business model actually feels safer to the human brain than the terrifying cure of the unknown.

So, if our brains are hardwired to sabotage our own decisions through optimism, confirmation bias, and the comfort of the familiar maze, we need a mathematical way to fight back.

Yes. And this is where the training introduces an unexpected historical figure. Thomas Bae, an 18th century minister. and his friend Richard Price.

What's fascinating here is how relevant 18th century mathematics is to modern boardroom psychology. They developed Bejjian theory, which is a weighted average model for applied decision-m.

The resource uses this as a framework to test how confident we are in new evidence independently of our original emotionally charged beliefs.

So, it acts as an incredible psychological cleanser. Instead of just arguing over a new piece of data, Bejjian theory forces the board to answer three these sequential questions.

Let's role play this. Actually, imagine you're the CEO and you firmly believe launching a new luxury product line is the key to saving the company.

Okay, I'm the CEO and I bring you a market research report saying customer demand is actually dropping.

Okay, so my instinct driven by optimism bias is to say your report is flawed and just dismiss it.

Right? But using the Beijing framework, question one asks, how confident are you in the truth of your initial belief? You have to quantify it.

Let's say I'm um 80% and confident the luxury line is a good idea.

Okay, question two. Assuming your original belief about the luxury line is true, how confident are you that this new negative market research is correct?

Well, if I'm definitely right, the report must be wrong. So, maybe 10% confident.

And then comes the crucial third question, the kicker. Independent of your original belief, pretending you never had that idea at all, how confident are you that the methodology of this new market research report is sound and correct?

Oh, wow. If I had detach myself from my pet project. I mean, the research firm we hired is actually top tier. Their data gathering was incredibly thorough. I'd have to admit, I'm 90% confident the report is accurate.

And just like that, the math forces you to detach your ego from your past decisions.

That's wild.

It prevents you from associating new information with old habits just to feel a false sense of security. You're forced to weigh the new evidence on its own merits.

It's brilliant in theory, but I mean, in the heat of a meeting with a million dollars on the line, people are going to pull out an 18th century calculator. How do we make this kind of rigorous quality decision an actual habit?

The resource provides a tangible tool for exactly that called the decision workpaper.

Okay.

It forces the board's hand by requiring them to formally record not just the final decision they reach, but the underlying logic.

So, writing it all down.

Yeah. It requires them to write down the counterarguments that were considered and dismissed. And crucially, they must define the early failure indicators for the project before before it ever launches.

Early failure indicators. I love that. You're literally forcing the optimism bias out of the room by demanding everyone agree on what failure looks like on day one.

Exactly.

If the project hits metric X, we shut it down. No emotional arguments allowed.

It creates an ongoing objective working method. You separate the absolute facts from the emotional variables before any money is ever spent.

So, at this point, our hypothetical board has secured their internal psychology with safe words and they've locked down on their cognitive biases with Beijian thinking and decision workpapers. The drivers are fully sober and paying attention.

What to say?

Now they have to look out the windshield at the road ahead. They have to apply this to external threats because having a calm, rational room means nothing if you don't practice formal risk management.

The expert materials draw a very sharp vital distinction here that completely changes how you view threats. They differentiate between risk and uncertainty. How so?

Well, the source puts it perfectly. Without uncertainty, there is no risk, only clear danger.

That single line completely reframes the concept for me. Because if you know for an absolute fact that stepping in front of a speeding bus will kill you, that's not a risk. That's a danger.

Right. You don't manage danger, you get out of the way.

Exactly. Risk only exists when you're dealing with uncertainty. When outcomes and probabilities are known possibilities, but they aren't guaranteed.

And to handle true uncertainty, the resource details a strict five-step formal risk management process.

What are the steps?

Step one is to establish context. Figuring out the specific consequence and probability categories for your industry. Step two is identifying the risks.

Makes sense.

Step three is evaluating them individually against that context. Step four is determining a risk strategy. And here the psychological brilliance really shines because you're only allowed four choices.

Only four.

Just four. You can accept the risk, avoid it entirely, reduce your exposure or transfer it to a third party like buying insurance.

Okay. And the last step, finally, step five is developing an action plan based on that choice.

Now, I want to play devil's advocate for a second. Establish context, identify, evaluate, strategize, act to a seasoned executive, that just sounds like basic corporate common sense. Why is a standard five-step list elevated to a dedicated core governance skill?

Because under the intense pressure of a failing business, common sense is the very first casualty.

Fair point.

When a company is losing millions or a competitor launches a disruptive product, the amygdala takes over. Those psyche errors we discussed earlier flare up. People panic.

So the turtle mentality kicks in. They hide or the exact opposite. Formal risk management is the mathematical antidote to a dangerous behavior. The sources call the shotgun mentality.

The shotgun mentality. Yeah. Right. That's the emotional assessment of ideas where people just ignore sound methodology entirely. They're panicking. So they just fire off random ideas and initiatives, hoping something, anything, hits the target.

Exactly. When a board member starts acting out of sheer terror, firing that shotgun, this rigid five-step process acts as a grounding anchor.

It slows them down.

You stop the meeting. You take the terrifying, amorphous threat, and you force the panicked brain to categorize it. You demand they quantify the probability. You force them to put it into one of four rigid boxes: accept, avoid, reduce, or transfer. systematically strips the paralyzing emotion away from the threat.

That's exactly what it does.

So, what does this all mean for the day-to-day operations? We've explored the deep psychology, the biases, the risk matrix, but how do we practically enforce this behavior month after month? Because we're humans, we get tired, and we inevitably revert to bad habits.

We do.

This is where the standard governance templates come in. But reviewing these sources, they aren't treating a meeting agenda as mere bureaucracy. They're treating these templates as psychological guard rails.

That is the perfect analogy. The forms and agendas are behavioral constraints. Take the annual board plan template provided in the pack. It isn't just a calendar, right?

It meticulously maps out the entire year in advance from strategic scenario planning in February to reviewing the CEO's performance in May all the way to director's induction in December. It completely removes the anxiety of what should we be focusing on today.

And the board agenda template is wild to look at. It doesn't just list the topics. It acts specific and time down to the minute.

Down to the minute.

Yeah. You have 15 minutes for board only time. Exactly 20 minutes for matters arising from previous minutes. It's a structural weapon designed specifically to defeat the taxi driver personalities we talked about.

Oh, absolutely.

When someone tries to hijack the meeting with an irrelevant tangent, the chair doesn't have to get into a personal argument. They just point to the agenda. The clock is the bad guy, not the chair.

And look at the conflicts of interest disclosure form as well. It demands extreme granular transparency.

Yeah. The sources use a specific example of a director named Bill Smith formally declaring his interest in Bill's giant burgers.

Right. It seems mundane, but formally recording these financial interests in close business relationships is the only mechanism to stop those assassin and power broker personas from secretly pulling rank based on outside influences.

The CEO report guidelines act as another massive guard rail. The resource states clearly that a CEO's report to the board shouldn't just be a pass fail summary of performance targets.

It needs more depth.

It must explicitly outline what they call foundation assumptions. The CEO literally has to put in writing, "These are the things we believe to be true and have hard evidence for versus these are the things we merely hope are true." That is a massive vulnerability check right there on the paper.

It forces the executive to confront their own optimism bias before the board even asks a single question. Yeah.

And when decisions are finally reached, they're locked in using a resolutions document. This template is accompanied by a very sobering reminder of the law.

Oh, right. The legal side.

The training pack highlights the New Zealand Companies Act 1993, sections 131, 134, and crucially 135, which deals with reckless trading.

Reckless trading. Wow.

It's a stark reminder that acting in bad faith or letting your unchecked ego run the company into the ground carries severe personal legal liability. The facade of a boardroom won't protect you from the law.

It brings us right back to our car analogy. These templates are the lane assist and automated braking features in a modern vehicle. When your inner turtle mentality tries to withdraw or your lab rat mentality fixates on running the same old failing maze, these strict agendas, time limits, and legally binding resolutions forcefully aggressively pull you back into the center lane.

That is the entire system at work. But there is one final crucial piece of the puzzle found in the governance play sheet.

Okay, what's that?

Before you implement a single one of these guardrails, you have to read the signs of whether an organization is actually ready for them. The play sheet outlines when it might actually be too early for formal governance.

Wait, how can an organization be too early for good decisionm?

Well, because if the core management itself is fundamentally ineffective, placing a sophisticated board on top of it won't fix anything.

Oh, I see.

The resource lists specific red flags to watch for. If business objectives are blunt, meaning they aren't measurable or time bound, or if there's no clear evidence that basic tasks can even be implemented on time. Most tellingly, if the existing culture currently accepts task failure as normal, or if people are just learning the hard way because there are zero feedback loops.

So, if the engine of the car is missing entirely, putting better drivers in the front seat isn't going to make the vehicle move.

Exactly. Governance assumes there is a functional forwardmoving operation to actually steer here.

Which brings us to the end of our deep dive today. Our mission was to figure out how this massive resource differs from standard off-the-shelf governance packs. And the answer is abundantly clear. It's defined by its profound, almost surgical focus on board member conduct.

Absolutely.

It recognizes a truth that most corporate manuals completely ignore. Procedures, agendas, and risk matrices are utterly useless if the human beings executing them are blindly navigating via ego, manipulation, and cognitive biases.

It demands that you fix the psychology of the room before you ever attempt to fix the spreadsheet.

So for you listening right now, I want you to reflect on your own boardrooms, whether that's a literal corporate table, a local PTA committee, or even a tense family discussion about finances. Look around that room.

Which manipulation tactic is currently derailing your team's potential? Are you dealing with an assassin operating in the shadows? A donkey refusing to budge? A fence mener avoiding the hard truth? Or maybe if you're being fiercely honest with yourself, are you sometimes the taxi driver?

It is a really challenging mirror to look into. But as Socrates noted at the very beginning of the material, it truly is the beginning of wisdom. This raises an incredibly important question though about the balance of power in modern business.

Let's leave you with something to chew on. We've talked all about how the board's ultimate purpose is to use these psychological tools and strict frameworks to reign in risk, demand evidence, and stop egos. and crashing the car. But what happens when your CEO is a charismatic, wildly successful visionary? Someone whose entire billion-dollar empire was built entirely on optimism bias and breaking every rule in the book. Can strict, rational Beijing governance ever truly coexists with visionary rulebreaking disruption? Or is a boardroom battle between the safe drivers and the speed demons absolutely inevitable? Think about that the next time you buckle up for a meeting.